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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

MINISTER SAUD LEAVING FOR AUSTRALIA TODAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

Minister for Foreign Affairs, Narayan Prakash Saud, is leaving for Perth, Australia, on Wednesday to participate in the 7th Indian Ocean Conference being jointly organised by the Government of Australia and India Foundation from February 9 to 10.

According to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Minister Saud is scheduled to address the Conference being organised on the theme, 'Towards a Stable and Sustainable Indian Ocean,' on February 10.

While in Perth, FM Saud will hold a bilateral meeting with Penny Wong, Minister for Foreign Affairs of Australia.

In the margins of the Conference, he is also scheduled to hold meetings with participating heads of delegation from friendly countries.

Likewise, the Foreign Minister will visit Wellington, New Zealand, for a bilateral meeting with his counterpart there, Winston Peters on February 14. The meeting will be preceded by the Second Foreign Ministry Consultation Meeting between the senior officials of the Ministries.

FM Saud is accompanied by his spouse Jyotshna Adhikari Saud and officials of the MoFA. Ambassador of Nepal to Australia, Kailash Raj Pokharel, will also join the Nepali delegation. The Minister will return to Kathmandu on February 15.

PANDEY NAMED GENERAL SECRETARY OF PARLIAMENT



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Padma Prasad Pandey has been appointed general secretary of the Federal Parliament of Nepal.

Pandey, who had previously held the position of Secretary of the House of Representatives, resigned from his post on Tuesday, paving the way for his appointment as the General Secretary.

President Ramchandra Paudel accepted his resignation and subsequently appointed him to the vital position.

The decision to appoint Pandey came after recommendations were made by Speaker Dev Raj Ghimire and National Assembly Chairman Ganesh Prasad Timilsina on December 11 last year.

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PHOTO: PM's SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' presenting Human Rights Award to Dr. Renu Rajbhandari in the capital on Tuesday.

Foreign exchange reserves enough for a year: NRB

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Feb. 6



There has been significant improvement in the external sector of the economy during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

The improvement in foreign currency reserves, balance of payments, current account and remittance inflows has remained seen until mid-January of the current fiscal year.

According to the current macroeconomic and financial status report published by the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) Tuesday, the foreign currency reserve of the first six months of the current fiscal year can support the import of goods and services for one year.

The foreign currency reserves reached an all-time high of Rs. 1,816.57 billion during the first half of the current fiscal year.

Foreign currency reserves added about Rs. 49 billion during a single month (mid-December 2023 to mid-January 2024). The foreign currency reserves were Rs. 1,767.04 billion in mid-December 2023.

According to NRB, the gross foreign exchange reserves increased by 18 per cent to Rs. 1816.57 billion in mid-January 2024 from Rs. 1539.36 billion in mid-July 2023.

In the US dollar terms, the gross foreign exchange reserves increased by 16.9 per cent to 13.69 billion in mid-January 2024 from 11.71 billion in mid-July 2023.

Of the total foreign exchange reserves, the reserves held by NRB increased by 18.9 per cent to Rs. 1600.23 billion in mid-January 2024 from Rs. 1345.78 billion in mid-July 2023.

Reserves held by banks and financial institutions (except NRB) increased by 11.8 per cent to Rs. 216.35 billion in mid-January 2024 from Rs. 193.59 billion in mid-July 2023.

The share of Indian currency in total reserves stood at 22.5 per cent in mid-January 2024.

Based on the imports of six months of 2023/24, the foreign exchange reserves of the banking sector are sufficient to cover the prospective merchandise imports of 14.1 months, and merchandise and services imports of 12.1 months, said the NRB.

Remittance of Rs. 120 billion received in a single month

According to the report, remittance inflows increased by 25.3 per cent to Rs. 733.22 billion in the review period compared to an increase of 24.3 per cent in the same period of the previous year.

In the US dollar terms, remittance inflows increased by 22.6 per cent to 5.52 billion in the review period compared to an increase of 13.9 per cent in the same period of the previous year.

The report showed that remittance of Rs. 120 billion has been received in a single month from mid-December 2023 to mid-January 2024 of the current fiscal year.

In the review period, the number of Nepali workers, both institutional and individual, taking first-time approval for foreign employment stood at 207,970 and taking approval for renew entry stood at 135,435.

In the previous year, such numbers were 275,643 and 142,548 respectively. Net transfer increased by 24 per cent to Rs. 799.51 billion in the review period. Such transfer had increased by 22.7 per cent in the same period of the previous year.

Further improvement in BoP and current account surplus

Meanwhile, there has been further improvement in the current account and balance of payment (BOP) during the review period.

The current account remained at a surplus of Rs. 161.62 billion in the review period against a deficit of Rs. 35.57 billion in the same period of the previous year.

In US dollar terms, the current account registered a surplus of 1.21 billion in the review period against a deficit of 279.6 million in the same period last year. In the review period, capital transfer decreased by 30 per cent to Rs. 3.11 billion and net foreign direct investment (FDI) remained a positive of Rs. 4.53 billion.

In the same period of the previous year, capital transfer amounted to Rs. 4.43 billion and net FDI amounted Rs.749.4 million.

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PROTECTION OF HUMAN RIGHTS PRIORITY OF GOVT: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government has highly prioritised protection and promotion of human rights. Speaking at a Human Rights Award ceremony organised in Singha Durbar on Tuesday, the Prime Minister said that the government had given utmost respect to all rights associated with human rights.

"Human Rights are the base of the Constitution of Nepal, laws, periodic plans, institutional arrangements and government policies and programmes." He said, "The government acknowledges the reality that without human rights, the protection of human dignity, values and civilisation cannot be ensured."

Stating that most of the human rights-related rights were included in the constitution, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the Human Rights Commission, National Women Commission and various other constitutional commissions were established with the responsibility for the protection and promotion of human rights and to conduct effective monitoring and oversight.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the constitution guarantees that the judiciaries would take action against violations of human rights. He said, "Respect, protection and promotion of human rights could be successful through the coordination of non-governmental organisations and civil society. Various awareness programmes have been conducted by mobilising organisations working in the field of human rights."

Human Rights Awards were presented to Dr. Renu Rajbhandari under individual category and Madhes Manab Adhikar Griha on institutional category.

'MISUSE OF TRADE UNIONS CAUSING PROBLEMS'

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Minister for Communications and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that problems have been faced since the delivery was as per the essence of the trade unions, while questions were raised over their misuse.

Minister Sharma said so while responding to the queries raised by parliamentarians in the clause-wise discussion on the Bill related to Security Printing Press at the House of Representatives' Committee for Education, Health and Information Technology on Tuesday.

"There would not have been any problems if the trade unions were used properly.

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Nepal, Italy agree to revitalise observatory lab

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Bilateral Technical Committee (BTC) between Italy and Nepal has decided to revitalise the use and role of the Pyramid Observatory Laboratory, established 35 years ago by Prof. Ardito Desio at 5,050 Meters near Mount Everest.

The meeting took place at the headquarters of the Nepal Academy of Science and Technology (NAST) in Khumaltar of Lalitpur on 4-5 February. Pyramid is a laboratory for human adaptation to the issues of the health of local populations' exposure to high altitude and indoor and outdoor pollution, water availability and sustainable development.

It also conducts research on the management of natural resources for agriculture and sustainable tourism on the highest and most emblematic mountains in the heart of Asia, of which Everest is a symbol. Italy and the Ev-K2-CNR project in collaboration with NAST, with the Pyramid Laboratory located below Everest, holds international scientific research in this iconic place not only for Nepal but for the entire world and for high-level scientists dealing with nature and the environment, the NAST informed in a statement issued after the meeting.

It also said that there is a long and deep friendship, relationship, and trust between Nepal and Italy, which has been renewed in recent days with the renewal of bilateral agreements and the approval of multiyear joint research projects. "The population, stakeholders, local administrations, and the scientific and academic community of Nepal have strongly focused their strategic interest on the full reactivation of the Pyramid Laboratory and scientific collaboration between Italy and Nepal," read the statement.

Speaking at the BTC meeting, Vice Chancellor of the NAST, Prof. Dr. Dilip Subba, highlighted the enhancement and boosting of cooperation between the two organisations aiming at developing new projects in Nepal.

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Protests continue to disrupt BPKIHS services

BY NISHA RAI
Dharan, Feb. 6



The atmosphere has been tense at the BP Koirala Institute of Health Sciences, Dharan, as students have resorted to a relay hunger strike, advocating for the swift resumption of their studies.

Dr. Om Shanti Rajat, President of the Student Welfare Association, disclosed that the students have been staging the hunger strike for the past six days under the banner 'Student's Will, Autonomous Medical Education'. They are urging authorities to ensure their constitutional rights by promptly resuming teaching-learning activities and conducting examinations at a full capacity," he said.

For the last 24 days, the institute has faced disruptions due to protests. The deadlock stems from the suspension of the promotion process for teachers, doctors, and employees at the BP Institute.

Despite an agreement made on December 18 to resume the promotion interview pending ministerial approval, the process remains in limbo, leading to civil disobedience protests by the teachers and staff welfare societies for over three weeks.

Dr. Rajat emphasised that while the demand for staff promotions is justified, the prolonged disruption directly impacts students, whose studies have been hindered. This marks the third instance of interruptions, with previous closures occurring from August 29 to September 12 and again from October 7 to November 9 last year. Jesidar Sah, one of the frustrated students, expressed concerns about the uncertainty surrounding their education and future.

During the ongoing 24-hour relay hunger strike, four students have fallen ill and are undergoing treatment. Dr. Rajat conveyed that the gravity of their protest could escalate to a fast-onto-death if their pleas go unheard. Approximately 1,200 graduate-level students face an uncertain future and the financial burden imposed on students due to fines for delayed tuition fee payments. The administration's focus on tuition fees and fines, rather than addressing the persistent interruptions in education, has drawn criticism.

Despite instructions from the Prime Minister and Chief Secretary to convene an executive committee meeting, the demands of teachers and staff remain unaddressed. The recent attempt during the meeting on January 22 and 23 to resolve the issues proved unsuccessful.

The situation is dire, not only for students but also for patients at BP Institute. The Student Welfare Society appeals for a swift resolution, urging all stakeholders, including the central government and the BP Institute's leadership, to intervene and facilitate the prompt resumption of teaching activities.

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(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 118,000
Worked Gold	: Rs. 117.450
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STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,085.71
Total Amount	: 2,591,534,907.76
No. of Share	: 7,624,376

NCC, ECN agree for export facilitation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

An agreement has been reached between the Nepal Chamber of Commerce (NCC) and the Export Council of Nepal (ECN) to reduce trade deficit and increase exports.

While welcoming the newly elected executive committee of the Council at the Chamber Building in Jamal, Kathmandu, the agreement was made to cooperate on various issues of policy reforms and possibilities for export facilitation.

There will be cooperation between the two organisations on matters ranging from policy formulation to customs facilitation for enhancing the production and export of goods, according to a press statement of the NCC.

President of NCC Rajendra Malla said that the expected benefits could not be obtained due to the inability to identify and promote exportable goods of the country. He said, "There is an export potential of more than Rs. 1,000 billion in the country. But even goods worth Rs. 150 billion have not been exported,"

He said that NCC would take initiatives to end the policy difficulties seen in export promotion. He said that customs administration should be made sound and effective along with policy reforms to reduce trade deficit.



PHOTO: TRN
Traders associated with Nepal Chamber of Commerce (NCC) and the Export Council of Nepal (ECN) exchange agreement papers.

Similarly, President Malla emphasised that a high-level quarantine lab be established in customs and provision of export subsidy be implemented effectively. He said that exports can be doubled if there is an arrangement to make direct payments online while exporting the goods.

He said that if agricultural products, handicrafts, herbs, tea, coffee and other products produced from all over the country can be collected and exported through an integrated export centre or export promotion house, the production costs will be reduced for small businessmen and benefits increased.

President Malla said that the trade deficit of the country has been growing over the year and it has started to be close to the size of the budget every year.

He said, "The country's huge trade deficit is also an obstacle to economic prosperity and development. In the absence of domestic production, dependence on agricultural products is increasing, and exports have not been facilitated even in areas with good potential."

In the meeting, the newly elected chairman of Export Council of Nepal Naresh Lal Shrestha said that the businessmen were suffering unnecessarily due to the lack of facilitation of the customs process.

COOPERATIVES SHOULD WIN DEPOSITORS' TRUST: CM SHARMA

RSS
Karnali, Feb. 6

Chief Minister of Karnali Province, Raj Kumar Sharma, has viewed cooperatives should maintain good governance and win depositors' trust. Development could be ensured with mobilization of people through cooperatives, he opined while addressing a province level workshop on 'cooperatives' problems and good governance promotion' organized by the province ministry at Birendranagar on Monday.

He further suggested that cooperatives could launch activities for income generation. Cooperative's role is vital for development as the constitution itself has envisioned socialism, CM Sharma reminded. CM Sharma viewed the problems facing cooperative sector could be addressed through proper policies at all three tiers of government.

According to him, province government was focused on economic prosperity and social justice which, he argued, would bring happiness in people. Good governance is essential to address problems seen in multiple sectors, he emphasized.

He also reminded that the government had adopted three-pillar policy for economic development where cooperatives, private and public build partnership and forward activities.

WOMEN ENTREPRENEURS' CONFERENCE IN BHAIRAHAWA

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

The Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) is set to organise the National Women Entrepreneurs Conference in Bhairahawa of Lumbini Province on February 16 and 17.

About 250 to 300 women entrepreneurs from all 77 districts of Nepal are expected to participate in the conference.

The conference is going to be organised under the leadership of Women Entrepreneurs Development Committee of the FNCCI in coordination and cooperation with FNCCI, Lumbini and Siddhartha Chamber of Commerce and Industry.

The conference is going to be organised under the leadership of Women Entrepreneurs Development Committee of the FNCCI in coordination and cooperation with FNCCI, Lumbini and Siddhartha Chamber of Commerce and Industry. The FNCCI informed in a statement on Tuesday that it was organising such conference for the first time.

"Women in Nepal have long been actively participating in the country's economy, but the contribution of women entrepreneurs is often underestimated. If the participation of women in the labour force increases by only 1 per cent, the Gross Domestic Product of Nepal can be increased by 0.3 per cent," read the statement.

Empowering women entrepreneurs will create jobs, improve access to finance and increase innovation, said the FNCCI.

According to the organiser, the conference is going to be organised to support the development, expansion and promotion of women entrepreneurs as well as women empowerment and entrepreneurship.

The conference will discuss financial and market access, possibilities and challenges of tourism, initiatives and arrangements made for young women and startups.

Construction of Amarpur-Dhungesanghu transmission line begins



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Nepal Electricity Authority has started the construction of Amarpur-Dhungesanghu 132 kV double circuit transmission line.

The transmission line begins from Amarpur Substation in Hilihang Rural Municipality of Panchthar and extends to Dhungesanghu Substation in Maiwakhola Rural Municipality of Taplejung.

According to the Nepal Electricity Authority, the construction of Amarpur-Dhungesanghu line has been started to interconnect Kabeli Corridor 132 kV transmission line from Lakhanpur (Damak Substation) to Amarpur Substation in Jhapa and Koshi Corridor 220 kV transmission line from Inaruwa Substation in Sunsari to Dhungesanghu via Basantapur in Sankhuwasabha.

The Basantapur-Inaruwa section under the Koshi Corridor has been brought into operation. The construction of Basantapur-Dhungesanghu section is in the final stage. The Kabeli Corridor is operational.

The foundation stone of Amarpur-Dhungesanghu 132 kV transmission line was laid in the presence of Chairman of Hillihang Rural Municipality, Ward Chairman and local residents on Monday, said the NEA.

A total of 67 towers will have to be constructed along the 19 km transmission line. Around 200 megawatts of electricity can be supplied from the Amarpur-Dhungesanghu transmission line.

Project chief Anup Gautam said that the Amarpur-Dhungesanghu 132 kV transmission line has been started to reliably and efficiently supply electricity to the hydropower projects constructed and to be built in the Kabeli river watershed area.

According to him, as Koshi and Kabeli Corridor transmission lines are interconnected, if there is a problem in Kabeli Corridor for any reason, the electricity connected to that line can be supplied to Koshi Corridor.

The electricity generated from the hydropower projects under construction and to be built in the Tamor River watershed area will be integrated into the national transmission system through Dhungesanghu substation.

The project was started in the fiscal year 2018/19 with an investment of about Rs. 1.20 billion from the government. A contract was signed in 2022 for the construction of the transmission line. Project chief Gautam said that all the works under the project are targeted to be completed in the fiscal year 2024/25.

Police seal Meenakshi Food Industry



PHOTO: TRN
Expired foods stored in Meenakshi Food Industry in Lalitpur. The industry has been sealed for selling expired food items.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Police have sealed Meenakshi Food Industry located in Mahalaxmi Municipality-8 in Lalitpur for selling expired and adulterated food items.

The industry has been accused of engaging in activities that adversely affect the health of the general consumer by re-labelling various expired food items and selling them in the market, according to the Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office.

In a joint operation conducted by the Crime Investigation Office and a team of the Department of Commerce, Supplies and Consumer Protection, the industry was sealed on Monday at the presence of the local representatives.

According to Superintendent of Police and spokesperson for the Crime Investigation Office, Rabindra Regmi, during the investigation, it was found the spirit for deleting manufacturing date, date relabeling machine, date-expired cornflakes of Farm City brand, Chocos, oats and muesli, and various spices of Badsaha brand were found.

The Department has instructed the owner of the industry to be present at the office within three days along with the documents of the factory.

Ajaya diamond partners with Al Ali



PHOTO: TRN
Owners of Ajaya Diamond extend partnership with Al Ali Group.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

International diamond brand of Ajaya has entered into a commercial partnership with the renowned Dubai-based conglomerate, Al Ali Group.

"This landmark partnership, formalised through the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) on Tuesday, aims to push Ajaya into the global market while fostering joint ventures in Nepal's thriving tourism industry," said the company in a statement.

Yaqoob Al Ali, Executive Chairman of Al Ali Group, and Rakesh Kumar Adukia of Ajaya signed the MoU, combining their expertise and investments to expedite Ajaya's global market presence.

Adukia expressed optimism about the partnership, and said, "Ajaya, introduced by a Nepali expert, aspires not only to flourish domestically but to make its mark on the global stage. Partnering with Al Ali Group brings together investment and expertise, paving the way for its rapid global establishment."

According to him, the MoU signifies a shared vision to attract foreign investment in Nepal's burgeoning hospitality sector, recognised as a highly appealing destination for global investors. Al Ali Group and Ajaya plan to pool resources for joint investments in Nepal's tourism sector in the days to come.

Al Ali emphasised the group's keen interest in Nepal's tourism potential. "We see a significant potential in Nepal's tourism sector. Al Ali Group wishes to collaborate in tourism and hospitality in Nepal, leveraging our extensive experience in the field. The MoU has made us very enthusiastic," He said.

Samsung chief Lee acquitted of financial crime

AP
Seoul, South Korea, Feb. 6

A South Korean court on Monday acquitted Samsung Electronics Chairman Lee Jae-yong of financial crimes involving a contentious merger between Samsung affiliates in 2015 that tightened his grip over South Korea's biggest company.

The ruling by the Seoul Central District Court could ease the legal troubles surrounding the Samsung heir less than two years after he was pardoned of a separate conviction of bribery in a corruption scandal that helped topple a previous South Korean government. The court said the prosecution failed to sufficiently prove the merger between Samsung C&T and Cheil Industries was unlawfully conducted with an aim to strengthen Lee's control over Samsung Electronics.

The ruling was criticized by activists, progressive politicians and commentators, who questioned how Lee could be innocent of all charges when he had previously been convicted in the separate case of bribing a former president while seeking government support for the merger. The People's Solidarity for Participatory Democracy, South Korea's biggest civic group, said the court failed to display "even a minimal level of social justice" by putting Lee's interests before those of shareholders and pensioners, whose retirement funds were possibly reduced by the deal, which was endorsed by the National Pension Service.

It described the ruling as a setback for years of efforts to reform the management culture of South Korea's family-owned conglomerates and their cozy ties with the government. South Korean corporate leaders often receive relatively lenient punishments for corruption, business irregularities and other crimes, with judges often citing concerns over the country's economy.

Prosecutors had sought a five-year jail term for Lee, who was accused of stock price manipulation and accounting fraud. It wasn't immediately clear whether they would appeal. Lee denied wrongdoing in the current case, describing the 2015 merger as "normal business activity." Lee, 55, did not answer questions from reporters as he left the court. You Jin Kim, Lee's lawyer, praised the ruling, saying it confirmed that the merger was legal.

Lee, a third-generation corporate heir who was officially appointed chairman of Samsung Electronics in October 2022, has led the Samsung group of companies since 2014, when his late father, former chairman Lee Kun-hee, suffered a heart attack.

Lee Jae-yong served 18 months in prison after being convicted in 2017 over separate bribery charges related to the 2015 deal. He was originally sentenced to five years in prison for offering 8.6 billion won ($6.4 million) worth of bribes to then-President Park Geun-hye and her close confidante to win government support for the 2015 merger, which was key to strengthening his control over the Samsung business empire and solidifying the father-to-son leadership succession.

Park and her confidante were also convicted in the scandal, and enraged South Koreans staged massive protests for months demanding an end to shady ties between business and politics. The demonstrations eventually led to Park's ouster from office. Lee was released on parole in 2021 and pardoned by South Korean President Yoon Suk Yeol in August 2022, in moves that extended a history of leniency toward major white-collar crime in South Korea and preferential treatment for convicted tycoons.

Some shareholders had opposed the 2015 merger, saying it unfairly benefited the Lee family while hurting minority shareholders. There was also public anger over how the national pension fund's stake in Samsung C&T, the merged entity, fell by an estimated hundreds of millions of dollars after Park pressured the National Pension Service to support the deal.

Prosecutors have argued that Lee and other Samsung officials caused damage to shareholders of Samsung C&T, which was a major construction company, by manipulating corporate assets to engineer a merger that was favorable to Cheil, an amusement park and clothing company where Lee had been the biggest shareholder.

Home Ministry forms panel to study emergency services



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MoHA) has formed a task force to study the issue of providing emergency services in an integrated manner.

An 11-member task force has been formed under the coordination of Bharatmani Pandey, Joint Secretary of the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA), to submit a concept paper and action plan within 15 days to provide integrated services such as ambulance, fire brigade, police and primary health.

According to a press note issued by the Ministry on Monday evening, the task force consists of a representative each from the Ministry of Home, Health, Communication and Information Technology, Ministry of Federal Affairs and General Administration, Nepali Army, and two members each from the Armed Police Force Nepal and Nepal Police.

Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Narayan Kaji Shrestha's Information and Communication expert Vijaya Gautam is also a member of the task force.

Nepal Police 100, Fire Brigade 101, Ambulance 102 and Traffic Police 103 are currently in use for emergency assistance services.

Deputy Prime Minister Shrestha's Secretariat has said that the task force will study and make suggestions on the issue of operating all these emergency services through a single setup.

Traffic police fines 27 for modifying motorcycles

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6



PHOTO: TRN

Valley traffic police are checking two-wheeler riders on its regular checks.

The traffic police have taken action against 27 motorcycle owners who caused noise pollution by changing the shape and design of their motorcycles and producing loud noise.

Since last Friday, the Kathmandu Valley Traffic Police Office, Ramshah Path, has taken action against the drivers who have changed the appearance of their bikes by conducting a campaign.

Police have also been taking action against owners of modified two-wheelers during regular checks.

The traffic police have intensified the checks as a few motorcyclists tend to modify silencers, lights, number plates, looking glass, socks and handles of their bikes, which leads to accidents.

Senior Superintendent of Police Rajendra Prasad Bhatta and Spokesperson for the Valley Traffic Police Office, said that the loud noise emitted by the modified vehicles directly affects the elderly, children and sensitive areas (schools and hospitals) and also causes noise pollution.

Spokesman Bhatta said that the changed parts of the motorcycles have been taken out and by maintaining the standards and their original shape when they find a modified motorcycle. In the Vehicle and Transport Management Act of 2049, there is a provision of a fine from Rs. 1,000 to Rs. 15,000 for driving a vehicle by changing the shape of the vehicle.

Over 130 leading scientists from 70 countries in capital

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6



PHOTO: ICIMOD

Izabella Koziell, Deputy Director General, ICIMOD addressing Intergovernmental Science-Policy Platform on Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services in Kathmandu.

Over 130 leading scientists and subject experts from 70 countries have arrived in Kathmandu for the third author meeting of the Intergovernmental Science-Policy Platform on Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services (IPBES) nexus assessment.

The assessment will examine the interlinkages among the sustainable development goals related to food and water security, health for all, protecting biodiversity, and combating climate change.

The meeting that began on February 5 will end on February 9 followed by a meeting to advance a summary for policymakers from February 10 to 11, 2024. The meetings are being jointly hosted by the Ministry of Environment and Forests of Nepal, and the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) and will take place at the ICIMOD headquarters in Kathmandu.

This is the first time an IPBES assessment meeting is being held in South Asia, according to a press statement issued by ICIMOD.

"In addition to the privilege of hosting an IPBES assessment author meeting of such importance, we see this as an opportunity to highlight critical biodiversity and related issues in the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH) to a very distinguished group of global experts and the IPBES Secretariat," said Izabella Koziell, Deputy Director General, ICIMOD. "To protect the HKH region, we must collaborate, make scaled investments, and forge partnerships for transformative change," Koziell added.

The overall aim of the nexus assessment is to facilitate an enhanced understanding of the complex and dynamic interrelationships between biodiversity, water, food, and health, in the context of climate change, and to identify options to improve policies and foster greater understanding and collaboration across the nexus-related sectors, the statement read.

Reflecting on the importance of the meeting for the region, Sunita Chaudhary, Ecosystem Services Specialist at ICIMOD and lead author for the assessment, said, "It is high time that global leaders and scientists recognise and act for mountains and mountain communities."

Nakul Chettri, Senior Biodiversity Specialist at ICIMOD also highlighted, "Global science-policy processes such as IPBES and IPCC could be instrumental in highlighting the fate of mountains that cover close to one-quarter of Earth's land surface."

"IPBES is very pleased that this vital author meeting – for the most complex assessment we have ever undertaken – is being hosted in Kathmandu," said Dr. Anne Larigauderie, Executive Secretary of IPBES. "The warm hospitality and invaluable expertise of our ICIMOD colleagues, combined with the awe-inspiring biodiversity and vistas of Nepal, provide excellent impetus for the final stages of the drafting process of the IPBES nexus assessment."

The IPBES assessment of invasive alien species, published in 2023, highlighted the threats that more than 3,500 of the more than 37,000 alien species introduced by humans to new regions and biomes worldwide pose to nature, economy, food security, and human health.

In addition to their role in 60 per cent of global plant and animal extinctions, the annual costs of biological invasions were estimated at more than a staggering $423 billion in 2019. Similarly, the IPBES Global Assessment Report on Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services, published in 2019, warned that nature was "declining at rates unprecedented in human history" and that some one million animal and plant species are now threatened with extinction, many within decades.

Cancer Hospital opens in Morang

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Feb. 6

Birat Medical College Teaching Hospital in Budhiganga Rural Municipality of Morang has brought the Rewanta-Rukmani Cancer Hospital into operation with an investment of Rs. 4 billion.

As part of the new infrastructure, a hospital has been established with modern equipment worth Rs. 1 billion for the treatment of cancer patients.

Dr. Gyanendra Man Singh Karki, Chairman of Birat Medical College Teaching Hospital, informed that the hospital has been brought into operation to provide comprehensive cancer treatment services.

He informed that the goal was to provide treatment at an affordable cost, and this is the second cancer hospital to be operated privately in Koshi Province.

Karki also said that investment has been made in the purchase of modern equipment. Competent doctors and specialised structures have facilitated cancer patients and the compulsion to go to Chitwan, Kathmandu or India for treatment is significantly reduced.

The hospital will provide services such as radiotherapy, medical oncology, chemotherapy, targeted therapy, immunotherapy, hormonal therapy, surgical oncology, radio-diagnosis, interventional radiology, stereotactic, mammography, and preventive oncology. Additionally, services such as preventive oncology, palliative care, pathology, and nutrition counselling will also be available at the hospital.

Karki claims that ten specialist doctors will provide services under the Cancer Department. The team including medical oncologist Dr. Gyanendra Man Singh Karki, Dr. Mona Priyadarshini, medical oncologist Dr. Sulabh Sapkota, cancer surgeon Dr. Shiva Ram Sharma, Dr. Dhrbva Narayan Sah, Dr. Narendra Pandit, paediatric oncologist Dr. Subas Mehta, paediatric cancer surgeon Dr. Hiramani Pathak, clinical oncologist Dr. Asmita Rayamajhi, Dr. Bivek Ghosh, radiologist Dr. Netrabikram Shah and Bhanupratap Shah are providing quality treatment for the cancer patients.

Birat Teaching Hospital claims to have provided OPD services to over 1.54 million individuals and indoor services to 271,723 individuals so far. There are 1,243 employees in the teaching hospital, and construction of 1200 beds has been completed.

Earlier, industrialist Rajendra Raut had laid the foundation stone of the hospital with an investment of Rs. 2.5 billion in Budhiganga Rural Municipality.

Nobel Teaching Hospital, government-owned Koshi Hospital, Neuro Hospital, Birat Hospital, and Biratnagar Eye Hospital are hospitals in Biratnagar that provide specialised services.

Free health camp held in Narainapur

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Feb. 6

Under the 'Nepali Congress with Community Campaign', a free health camp was conducted in Narainapur, a remote village in Banke district.

Nepal Trade Union Congress and Nepal Health Workers Association, Banke, with the technical support of Nepalgunj Medical College Teaching Hospital in Kohalpur, organised the health camp in Narainapur-3.

Central member of the Nepali Congress Guru Baral inaugurated the camp on Monday. He expressed that the Congress campaign aims to support the party to reach every household and connect the people with the party. He mentioned that the campaign aims to directly connect the community with the Nepali Congress to increase the party's popularity.

Narayan Prasad Gaudel, the president of the Nepali Congress Banke, said that such campaigns would be very effective in making the Nepali Congress the largest party in the district.

According to Yam Bahadur Khadka, one of the campaigners, health check-ups were conducted by Dr. Santosh Bhagat, Dr. Chetan Neupane from the Medicine Department, and Dr. Ramesh Sharma Paudel and Dr. Nupendra Shishir from the Department of Dermatology and Venereal Diseases, respectively.

The health camp was supported with free medicines by Satguru Medicine Distributors, Sirjana Medicine Distributors and Laxmi Saraswati Polyclinic, Nepalgunj.

Many locals expressed happiness over the health camp being conducted in their remote area, where accessibility to healthcare is very limited.

Local leader Naresh Khatri said that such health camps had become a good medium for providing treatment, especially considering the backwardness of Narainapur in terms of healthcare services.

Only two pillars of bridge stand in nine years

BY SHER BAHADUR SARKI
Bajura, Feb. 6



PHOTO: TRN

Two pillars constructed at Barjugad Khola connecting Khaptad Chhededaha Rural Municpality-3 and Budhiganga Rural Municpality-4 in nine years.

Construction of a bridge over the Barjugad Khola connecting Khaptad Chhededaha Rural Municpality-3 and Budhiganga Rural Municpality-4 in Bajura district has not been completed even nine years after the work began.

A contract for the construction of the 45-metre-long bridge was awarded to Achham's Saud Adventure JV in 2015 for Rs. 20 million with a deadline of 2019. However, the company has constructed only two pillars of the bridge in nine years.

Khadak Khadka, a local from Tunisain in Ward No. 3 of the rural municipality, said that the construction work had not been completed even nine years after the work on the project began. The delay has caused inconvenience to locals in crossing the Barjugad River, and even deaths.

On June 25 last year, 23-year-old Sangita Saud of Gwaniki in Khaptad Chhededaha Rural Municipality-4 lost her life while crossing the river.

Khadka complained that the construction company had been extending the deadline and their pain had remained unaddressed.

Meanwhile, Ramesh Saud, a representative of the construction company, said that the construction work was delayed due to a landslide at the place where the first layout was prepared. It took time for them to conduct a soil test in the second location.

He said, "After preparing a report on the soil test, we have now started constructing a bridge at the second location. Approximately 70 per cent of the construction work has been completed." He said that the work got delayed since the Galaxy Engineering Company took two years to deliver the construction materials. Now, almost all materials have arrived, he added.

Saud assured that the construction work would be completed within a few months.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Freedom consists not in doing what we like, but in having the right to do what we ought.
-- Pope John Paul II

EDITORIAL

Rising Risk Of Cancer

Cancer treatment and care have advanced by leaps and bounds due to evolution of cutting-edge technology. As a result, it is now possible to prevent, detect, treat, and extend life of cancer patients. Despite this progress, many challenges still remain, particularly in the early detection and availability of state-of-the-art treatments for many. According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), cancer is a leading cause of death worldwide, accounting for nearly 10 million deaths annually. The most common cancer deaths are related to lung, colon, rectum, liver, stomach, and breast. Around 40 people die from cancer every day in Nepal, thanks to late detection and treatment. This alarming figure highlights the importance of implementing comprehensive and immediate measures to overcome the health crisis. To tackle this issue effectively, it's crucial to grasp the factors behind this surge. This will help in taking appropriate measures to tackle the menace of deadly disease.

Sedentary lifestyles, increasing pollution, unhealthy diets, negligence, and the general prevalence of tobacco use have been identified as major factors responsible for increasing cancer cases. To reverse this lifestyle trend, there is a need for the public to have structured and reliable awareness and outreach programmes. Interventions such as cervical cancer prevention through the HPV vaccine and advocating for hepatitis B vaccination play key roles in controlling the rate of these cancers. The high cost of cancer treatment, particularly for medications and advanced technologies like robotic surgery, worsens the accessibility challenges. This poses a significant barrier to affordable healthcare for cancer patients. Cancer care interventions are available in the country for 99 per cent of cancer patients. However, the lack of access to the latest technology raises concerns about the country's readiness to address this health challenge.

The government is developing the National Cancer Control Strategy 2080–87 to combat cancer and decrease mortality and prevalence rates. However, there are concerns regarding the strategy's effectiveness due to the shortage of vital equipment, including radio therapy machines. Prolonged waiting times for treatment further exacerbate the challenges of delivering timely care. Health experts emphasise the need for awareness and early detection for battling cancer more effectively. Delayed medical attention often hampers recovery chances, but timely hospital visits can save lives. Financial challenges and a lack of awareness create gaps in accessing necessary healthcare for different types of cancer. Despite the significant challenges, the dedication of healthcare professionals and ongoing awareness efforts offer hope in the relentless battle against cancer.

Educational campaign is essential for early diagnosis and treatment access. The government engages health workers and provides financial aid through programmes like the Indigent Citizen Drug Treatment Fund. Its continuous efforts to reduce tobacco use and vaccination drive to prevent cervical cancer demonstrates a commitment for comprehensive healthcare. However, there is a long way to go to ensure early diagnosis and access to treatment. A comprehensive approach is necessary to tackle various types of cancer cases, focusing on prevention, diagnosis, and treatment. Collaboration among individuals, healthcare professionals, and the government is vital in fighting this disease. Lifestyle changes, regular exercise, access to safe food items, and accessible treatments are essential. It's crucial to bridge the care gap and ensure no one is left behind in the fight against cancer.

Craze For Internet Fads

DIXYA POUDEL

In the vastness of the internet, one can perceive a myriad selection of fads which range from diet and exercise to health, lifestyle and wellbeing. As such, fads are short-lived trends that go viral online.

Today, social media has become a haven for internet fads. Very often, the content of a short video in TikTok, a reel in Instagram or a post in Facebook make such an impact that they amass millions of views. They range from frivolous (cat videos) to solemn (mental health suggestions).

Internet has a plethora of self-acclaimed lifestyle coaches and even specialists who dispense suggestions for an improved life. Particularly diet and nutrition; lifestyle and fashion; art, home and décor; fitness and exercise; meditation and mindfulness; and motivation are common areas where the internet speaks its mind quite voluminously.

There are accounts on social media where nutritionists, fitness coaches, fashion stylists, motivational speakers and so on share their knowledge and expertise which pledge to change people's lives for the better.

On a regular basis, they dispense advice on how to dress, communicate, imbue confidence, exercise, meditate, cook up a recipe, etc. And they make an impact on people as seen in the deluge of grateful comments. In doing so, it sets in motion a new online fad or trend.

It is not new to the internet to cater to the queries and necessities of its billions of users. But as the internet users have an attention span of a goldfish, online fads tend to last for only a short period of time.

Every now and then, some of them are memorable with a good cause. Remember the Ice Bucket Challenge for ALS (Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis) which earned $115 million for the ALS Association.

Fads can thus come in form of challenges on the social media with videos that appeal to the larger audiences who engage in such content and share them profusely in their social networking sites.

Many viral videos that make an online fad or a trend tend to create a buzz through an engaging, humorous or even explanatory content.

They are subject to extensive reactions from viewers. Once viral, they reach a large audience, helping many on the way, or simply bringing a smile or a chuckle to the viewers.

Such growing vogues on the internet show their ubiquitous presence. Even internet applications become a trending and often controversial subject such as ChatGPT which is a generative AI (Artificial Intelligence) tool built to answer queries in a conversational manner.

AI or not, internet trends continue to exert their impact on the users as internet strides to evolve and adapt to the human world. Tech giants are investing billions of dollars to improve the efficacy of the internet which is why it could help to be more aware of its implications.

Although fads are for a shorter term, they are likely to make a strong impact, even negative ones as well. As such, viral videos are known to spread misinformation as seen in the COVID pandemic or even in the elections.

Thus, instead of taking such trends by their face value, internet users today must be able to discern facts from fads by being cognizant of the evidences, sources and credentials available online.

Civic Participation Key To Democracy

Yuba Nath Lamsal



Of late the word 'democracy' has been a modern political lingua franca across the world. Democracy, in Abraham Lincoln's words, is the political system 'of the people, for the people and by the people'. In other words, democracy is the people's polity in which representatives govern in the name of people and for the larger interest of the people. In democracy, multiple ideas and views have equal role to play wherein dissenting voice is duly heard and well respected. Rulers and leaders alike in every country try to legitimise their rule in the name of people and claim that their regimes are democratic, irrespective of the form of government and political system they inherit or practice. Even those who rule with iron fist claim to have done so in the name of the people. Democracy is, thus, the most used and abused political terminology in the world.

Politics evolves along with the evolution of human civilisation. So is democracy. The nature of politics has changed with the wheel of time and history. Power is the central focus of politics in which tricks and treachery are the common phenomenon to grab power. Politics is no longer virtuous vocation as prophesied by Socrates. Nor does Immanuel Kant's, politics of morality is at play. Politics of the day is Machiavellian in which fundamental purpose of politics is power and anything is fair to gain and hold on to power.

Idea of democracy

In the history of human civilisation particularly since the emergence of the first state in Sumer, which is now located in south-central Iraq. It was later called Mesopotamia, various forms of political systems and shapes came to dominate in the world. The origin of democracy in the western world goes back to 500 BC. In 507 BC, Cleisthenes, a nobleman in Athens is credited to have mooted the idea of democracy. Cleisthenes announced a constitution comprising of some rudimentary tenets of modern democracy like three branches of government -- executive, legislative and judiciary and their independent role. Cleisthenes is, therefore, called the father of democracy in the western world.

In the oriental society the roots of democratic culture goes back to even older time. Kautilya's Arthasashtra and Niti Shashtra tell about how a ruler should govern in the larger interest of the people in 3rd century BC, which is said to be the rudimentary form of democracy. Kautilya or Chanakya was the principal advisor to the Maurya emperor Chandragupta of Magadha kingdom (presently in India). Kautilya's concept of the ruler (king) is of benevolent type whose primary task is welfare of the common people. Chinese are of the view that Confucius teachings, too, talk about some basic democratic tenets. And thus, they are of the view that democracy is rooted in oriental civilisations and more particularly Asian civilisations.

Whatever the claims and counter-claims on the origin and roots of democracy, the fundamental goal of democracy is to serve the people. However, the present day interest-based politics is devoid of virtues and morality. Instead politics is not the vocation of the gentlemen instead it is called a dirty game. In the name of realpolitik, politics has gotten perverted and corrupted. As George Bernard Shaw has said 'Politics is the last resort for the scoundrel' statecraft is often handled by dirty hands. Rulers and leaders tend to capture power in the name of democracy and people. As a result, democracy, too, has earned bad repute and the sanctity of democracy has evaporated.

> Democracy cannot survive and prosper in the absence of greater and active participation of the people in politics and electoral process.

In principle, majority of the countries in the world are democratic. Despite constitutional provisions of democracy, only a few countries are genuine democracy. Constitutional provisions alone do not ensure democracy. Democracy has to be seen, felt and realised in the life of the people for which actions and government's delivery count more than anything. In other words, democracy is a political culture which accepts and ensures plurality in all fronts. Monopoly is incompatible with the democratic principle. Democracy treats all equally and guarantees equal access to opportunities.

According to the global democracy index of the Economist Intelligence Unit, only 8 per cent of the world's population actually lives in a full and functioning democracy, while 37 per cent of people live in "flawed democracy", while 55 per cent does not live in democracy at all. The global democracy index puts Norway on the top of the list of ensuring full democracy followed by Iceland, while Sweden, New Zealand and Canada rank in the third, fourth and fifth position respectively. Democracy is active participation of the people in the political process. However, the participation of the people in democracy is dwindling. Election is one of the opportunities for people's participation.

Growing public apathy

However, elections alone are not the lone gauge of democracy. Elections are held also in non-democratic countries, too. The issue is not whether elections are held or not but the real matter is how elections are held. People's participation in electoral and political process has been diminishing worldwide. There has been growing public apathy towards politics. Democracy cannot survive and prosper in the absence of greater and active participation of the people in politics and electoral process. Democracy is the political system that requires greater transparency, efficient delivery of services and high degree of accountability.

When parties and leaders fail in delivery part and tend to focus more on personal and partisan gains, democracy turns demagoguery and plutocracy. This is exactly what has happened in most of the developing democracies and some already established democracies are, too, not immune to this syndrome. Politics is getting a bad reputation because of the behaviour of political parties and leaders. This has, to some extent, degraded the quality of democracy worldwide. Until and unless, political players do not see themselves and their activities through the eyes of people, politics will continue to be a 'dirty game'. Now is the time to clean politics and enhance the quality of democracy for which politicians have to make a serious soul searching as to what has gone wrong and what needs to be reformed.

(The author is former ambassador and former chief editor of this daily. lamsalyubanath@gmail.com)

Social Movement Calls For Just Global Order

Namrata Sharma



INSIGHT

This age is supposed to be the most advanced age in human civilisation. However, physical wars, psychological control by the haves over the have-nots and environmental degradation all over the world have given rise to autocracy and fundamentalism even in the most democratic countries. The situation of gender apartheid in Afghanistan and the atrocities against the common Palestinian people as a backlash to the Hamas is a slap in the face of 75 years of the declaration of the Human Rights Charter. Why has this modern age world not been able to protect the rights, guaranteed by the UN Charter and several countries all over the world, of the most vulnerable people?

The World Economic Forum, led by powerful world leaders and corporate giants, was hosted in Davos in January. The World Social Forum (WSF), which is a movement generated as an anti-globalisation movement of the 2000, led by common people is now to be hosted on February 15-19, 2024 in the Kathmandu Valley. Nearly 900 organisations from 73 countries will be here for WSF. The WSF has an anti-neoliberal global capitalist agenda seeing it as the root cause of militarism, imperialism, conflict, north-south inequity and the climate crisis.

International debate

"A right-winged politics is increasing fundamentalism in different ways and forms globally, sometimes as national fundamentalism and sometimes as religious and even sexist. So far Nepal is seen as grounds where open debate can be raised on these issues," says Dr Renu Adhikary, a human rights activist. Dr Adhikary said the WSF organisers were highly optimistic that the international debate that would happen here would help national and global networks to take their agendas ahead in the future and also put pressure on the world politicians to face moral obligations to take affirmative actions.

WSF has been organised as an open space and platforms since 2001 for the convergence of a diverse range of participants, including social movements, labourers, farmers, civil society groups, marginalised communities, and those affected by neoliberal capitalism and privatisation. The WSF forum aims to create reflective thinking, deliberate democratic debate of ideas, formulate proposals, a free exchange of experiences and interlink for effective actions. In 2001, the first WSF was held in Porto Alegre, Brazil, with the vision "Another World Is Possible". In 2024, it is happening in Nepal with the theme of "Another World Now". Since 2001 WSF has been held in different places around the world, including Caracas, Venezuela, Bamako, Mali, Karachi, Nairobi, Belem, Dakar, Tunis, Montreal, Salvador, Mumbai and now in Nepal. In 2021 during the COVID-19 pandemic WSF was a virtual event.

In collaboration with the Asia Pacific Social Forum – Facilitation Committee (APSF-FC) and the International Council (WSF-IC) the Nepal Organising Committee (NOC) is hosting this year's WSF in the Kathmandu valley with an expectation of hosting 30,000 international and Nepali delegations. The major events are to be held in the open space of Brikuti Mandap while places like the Rastra Sabha Griha, Ratna Rajya Campus, St Xaviers College, Nepal Tourism Board and Balmiki Campus, among others, will be holding different sessions and events.

> Nepal is indeed seen as a place where our political leaders are accessible to the people and our press is also relatively free.

Therefore, during this period, people arriving from all over the world and from within Nepal will be meeting, discussing and raising issues to attract the attention to the injustices faced by people all over the world. The local civil society organisations within Nepal are collaborating with such organisations all over the world to host various sessions on thematic areas ranging from how to combat hate speech in the digital age which is one of the latest form of atrocities that the world is facing today to raising issues of the Dalit, which has been raised as a crime against humans since centuries.

The brochure of the WSF 2024 states that the people of the planet are currently facing an unprecedented environmental crisis coupled with rising inequalities, widespread food insecurities, majoritarian violence, after-effects of the last pandemic and the threat of a future one, together with the escalating tensions between major powers. They stress on the fact that humanity is on the brink of multifaceted calamities, leading to the destruction of its own survival. The WSF 2024 aims to foster the ideals of the new world order that rests upon sustainability, dignity, co-existence, equality, and equity by pledging that "Another World is Possible".

Convergence of opinions

The opening ceremony is to commence with a solidarity march, culminating at the Bhrikuti Mandap on 15th. Parallel sessions will be held throughout 16-18th when networking and alliance building are done. On the 19th, the last day, there will be convergence of opinions where statements will be issued for future work and activities. During this event, an International Youth Forum and Camp will be organised on 17-19th February. Around 300 youths from all over the world are expected to come and raise their voices on different topics mentioned above.

Similarly, the World Feminist Forum (WFF) is being held. "About 30 Nepali organisations with seven to eight international networks are taking the lead in organising the WFF during the WSF. We are aiming to alert the world leaders on important matters that are being neglected," said Dr Adhikary, one of the organisers of WFF. Freedom of press and expression of opinion are the key agendas of the WSF. Nepal is indeed seen as a place where our political leaders are accessible to the people and our press is also relatively free, especially when compared to both our neighbours India and China. February is the time for Nepal to welcome guests from all over the world to raise voices in unison in order to move the world towards a free, fair and equitable place where all can live with dignity.

(Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate namrata1964@yahoo.com Twitter handle: @NamrataSharmaP)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 7, 1974

Training For Women

Silgadhi, Feb 6. (RSS)

A three month long training programme for women was opened at Payal village last week.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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READER'S MAIL

Nepal Has Huge Tourism Prospect



I am writing in reference to a news report '*More than 79,000 foreign tourists visit Nepal in January*' which was published in the digital edition of this daily on February 1, 2024.

Certainly, Nepal is a well-known tourist's destination. It is known as the land of Mount Everest as enthusiastic travellers seek to trek in this mountainous nation. Other tourists' sites include Pokhara valley with its beautiful lakes, hills, and mountains. The capital city too is famous among travellers due to its ancient temples and monuments.

The three Durbar Squares namely, Hanuman Dhoka Durbar Square, Bhaktapur Durbar Square and Patan Durbar Square have beautiful temples and historic buildings. Pashupatinath, Swaymbhunath and Boudha Stupa too offer a historic and religious place to visit for travellers in Nepal. There are also various National Parks and Reserves famous in the nation. Due to its rich cultural, traditional and natural sites, Nepal is known on the world map. And it is encouraging to see thousands of foreign tourists visiting Nepal.

Raju Rimal
Pokhara

TAILPIECE

A minister delivered a sermon in 10 minutes one Sunday morning, which was about half the usual length of his sermons. He explained, "I regret to inform you that my dog, who is very fond of eating paper, ate that portion of my sermon which I was unable to deliver this morning." After the service, a visitor from another church shook hands with the preacher and said, "Reverend, if that dog of yours has any pups, I want to give one to my minister."

Magistrate: "What was he doing when you arrested him?"

Policeman: "He was arguing with a taxi driver, Your Honor."

Magistrate: "That is no proof he was drunk."

Policeman: "Well, Your Honor, there was no taxi driver there."

Blinken seeks progress on Gaza cease-fire-for-hostages deal

AP
Cairo, Feb. 6

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken was in Cairo on Tuesday for a meeting with Egyptian leaders that U.S. officials said would concentrate on negotiating a cease-fire in the Israel-Hamas war in exchange for the release of hostages held by the militants.

Blinken's visit also comes amid growing concerns in Egypt about Israel's stated intentions to expand the combat in Gaza to areas on the Egyptian border that are crammed with displaced Palestinians.

Israel's defense minister has said Israel's offensive will eventually reach the town of Rafah, on the Egyptian border, where more than half of Gaza's 2.3 million people have sought refuge and are now living in increasingly miserable conditions.

U.N. humanitarian monitors said Tuesday that Israeli evacuation orders now cover two-thirds of Gaza's territory, driving thousands more people every day toward the border areas.

Egypt has warned that an Israeli deployment along the border would threaten the peace treaty the two countries signed over four decades ago. Egypt fears an expansion of combat to the Rafah area could push terrified Palestinian civilians across the border, a scenario Egypt has said it is determined to prevent.

Blinken, who was meeting Tuesday with Egyptian President Abdel-Fattah el-Sissi, has said repeatedly that Palestinians must not be forced out of Gaza.

During his latest trip, Blinken is seeking progress on a cease-fire deal, on potential normalization of relations between Israel and Saudi Arabia, and on preventing an escalation of regional fighting.

On all three fronts, Blinken faces major challenges. Hamas and Israel are publicly at odds over key elements of a potential truce. Israel has dismissed the United States' calls for a path to a Palestinian state, and Iran's militant allies in the region have shown little sign of being deterred by U.S. strikes.



PHOTO: AP

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken leaves with Saudi Arabia's Minister of State and National Security Musaed Al Aiban, right, after a meeting with Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, Monday, Feb. 5, 2024.

Egypt — along with Qatar, where Blinken will be later Tuesday — have been trying to mediate an agreement between Israel and Hamas that would lead to the release of more hostages in return for a several-week-long pause in Israeli military operations. The outlines of such a deal were worked out by intelligence chiefs from the U.S., Egypt, Qatar and Israel late last month and have been presented to Hamas, which has not yet formally responded.

U.S. officials said Blinken is hoping to get an update on Hamas' response to the proposal in both Cairo and Doha. Blinken will then travel to Israel to brief Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his War Cabinet on Wednesday about what he heard from the Arab leaders.

As on his previous four trips to the Mideast since the Gaza war began, Blinken's other main goal is to prevent the conflict from spreading, a task made exponentially more difficult by stepped up attacks by Iran-backed militias in the region and increasingly severe U.S. military responses in Iraq, Syria, Yemen and the Red Sea that have intensified since last week.

Blinken met with Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman on Monday evening, shortly after arriving in the Saudi capital, Riyadh. Saudi officials have said the kingdom is still interested in normalizing relations with Israel in a potentially historic deal, but only if there is a credible plan to create a Palestinian state.

Blinken "underscored the importance of addressing humanitarian needs in Gaza and preventing further spread of the conflict," and he and the crown prince discussed "the importance of building a more integrated and prosperous region," the State Department said in a statement.

But any such grand bargain appears a long way off as the war still rages in Gaza.

The Palestinian death toll from nearly four months of war has reached 27,585 according to the Health Ministry in the Hamas-run territory, with the bodies of 107 people brought to hospitals over the past day. The ministry does not distinguish between civilians and combatants in its count but says most of the dead have been women and children.

The war has levelled vast swaths of the tiny enclave and pushed a quarter of residents to starvation.

U.N. humanitarian monitors said Tuesday that Israel's evacuation orders in the Gaza Strip now cover two-thirds of the territory, or 246 square kilometres (95 square miles). The affected area was home to 1.78 million Palestinians, or 77% of Gaza's population, before Hamas' Oct. 7 cross-border raid that ignited the war.

The U.N. Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, or OCHA, said in its daily report that the newly displaced only have about 1.5-2 litters (50-67 ounces) of water per day to drink, cook and wash. It also reported a significant increase in chronic diarrhea among children.

'King Charles III's cancer caught early'



FILE PHOTO: AP

King Charles III welcomes Rishi Sunak during an audience at Buckingham Palace, London. Britain's King Charles III has been diagnosed with cancer and has begun treatment, Buckingham Palace said Monday Feb. 5, 2024.

AP
London, Feb. 6

British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak said Tuesday that he was "shocked and sad" to learn that King Charles III has cancer, but is relieved that the illness was caught early.

Buckingham Palace announced Monday evening that the king has begun outpatient treatment for an undisclosed form of cancer. It was found during his recent treatment for an enlarged prostate but is not connected to that condition, the palace said.

"Thankfully, this has been caught early," Sunak told BBC radio, adding that as prime minister he would "continue to communicate with him as normal."

"He'll just be in our thoughts and our prayers. Many families around the country listening to this will have been touched by the same thing and they know what it means to everyone," Sunak said. "So we'll just be willing him on and hopefully we get through this as quickly as possible."

Less than 18 months into his reign, the 75-year-old monarch has suspended public engagements but will continue with state business — including weekly meetings with the prime minister — and won't be handing over his constitutional roles as head of state.

The palace said Charles, who has generally enjoyed good health, "remains wholly positive about his treatment and looks forward to returning to full public duty as soon as possible."

Charles became king in September 2022 when his mother, Queen Elizabeth II, died at the age of 96 after 70 years on the throne.

News of the king's diagnosis comes as his daughter-in-law Kate, Princess of Wales, recovers from abdominal surgery that saw her hospitalized for about two weeks.

Senegalese MPs vote to delay presidential poll, protests spark

AFP
Dakar, Feb. 6

Senegalese lawmakers voted late Monday to delay this month's presidential election until December, an unprecedented move that has sparked international concern over a country normally seen as a beacon of stability in West Africa.

The bill was passed near unanimously, with 105 votes in favour and one against, after opposition deputies were forcibly removed from the chamber.

It paves the way for President Macky Sall to remain in office until his successor is installed, despite growing concern about the erosion of democracy.

"The situation is completely catastrophic, Senegal's image is ruined, and I don't think we'll be recovering from this democratic bankruptcy, this tsunami in the rule of law, any time soon," opposition deputy Ayib Daffe said after the vote.

Earlier, security forces outside used tear gas to disperse small groups of opposition protesters, with demonstrators chanting "Macky Sall dictator".

The atmosphere in Senegal has been tense since Saturday when Sall announced a delay to the February 25 vote, just hours before campaigning was officially set to begin.

"Let's not be an assembly of shame. Let's make sure that when we leave here we can look at our children with pride and say that we were the last wall, the last bulwark," said opposition MP Abass Fall during the debate over the postponement.

Adopted a day earlier by a preparatory committee, the proposal for the election delay was supported by MPs from Sall's party, which has been unable to fully coalesce around the president's favoured successor.

"President Macky Sall said he would serve two terms. He has kept his word," said MP Moussa Diakhate, chairman of the pro-government law committee.

Violence has previously broken out in Senegal over fears Sall would try to extend his tenure beyond the end of his second term, and he has previously insisted he would not.

The sporadic clashes outside parliament were a rare sight in the normally calm area of downtown Dakar, where police and security forces backed up by heavy vehicles, were mobilised to protect parliament.

Demonstrator Malick Diouf, 37, said he had no preferred candidate and did not even have a voting card, but felt it crucial to come and protest.

"The main thing for me is to say 'no' to this political agenda, this coup de force to try to stay in power," he told AFP.

Opposition leaders had denounced the proposed delay as a "constitutional coup" and an assault on democracy.

Violent street protests rocked the capital Dakar on Sunday, and two opposition candidates, including former prime minister Aminata Toure, were arrested and later released.

Storm kills 3; flash flood alerts still in effect in LA

AP
Los Angeles, Feb. 6

A storm of historic proportions dumped a record amount of rain over parts of Los Angeles on Monday, sending mud and boulders down hillsides dotted with multimillion-dollar homes while people living in homeless encampments in many parts of the city scrambled for safety.

About 710,000 people state-wide were without power Monday evening.

The storm was the second one fuelled by an atmospheric river to hit the state over the span of days.

Virtually all of Southern California was under flash flood advisories and watches, including the Los Angeles area, where between 5 and 10 inches (12.7 to 25.4 centimetres) of rain had fallen and more was expected, according to the National Weather Service. At the downtown measuring station, 6.7 inches of rain had fallen by Monday afternoon, nearly half the yearly average of 14.25 inches. It was already the third-wettest two-day period since 1877, the service said.

So far officials have attributed three deaths to the storm that first hit Northern California. Crews rescued people from swift-moving water in various parts of Southern California on Monday, including 16 people and five cats in Los Angeles County alone, authorities said.



PHOTO: AP

A firefighter walks past vehicles submerged by a mudslide Monday, Feb. 5, 2024, in the Beverly Crest area of Los Angeles.

Also rescued were two homeless people who spent the night on a small island in the Santa Ana River in San Bernardino, about 55 miles (88.51 kilometres) east of Los Angeles, authorities said.

"They were cold and exhausted from a night out stranded on this little patch of dirt that was in the middle of the river," said Capt. Nathan Lopez of the San Bernardino County Fire Department. A dog and two cats were also saved.

At a news conference, authorities said rain would taper off in intensity on Tuesday, but the threat of flooding remained high.

Near the Hollywood Hills, floodwaters carried mud, rocks and household objects downhill through Studio City, damaging at least two homes, city officials said. Sixteen people were evacuated.

The Los Angeles Fire Department said 1,000 fire-fighters were contending with 49 debris flows, 130 reports of flooding, half a dozen structure fires and several rescues of motorists stranded in vehicles.

Drake Livingston who lives in the Beverly Crest neighbourhood, was watching a movie around midnight when a friend alerted him to flooding.

PRISM

Snake escapes winter cold by invading home

British Columbia: Wildlife experts in British Columbia are caring for a great basin gopher snake that decided to invade a resident's home instead of going to sleep for the winter.

Interior Wildlife Rehabilitation Society said the snake, which is native to the area, was found awake and active inside an Okanagan home at the time of year when most of its fellow reptiles are in an inactive state of brumation, a cold-blooded creature's version of hibernation.

Eva Hartmann, founder of the nonprofit, said the rehabilitation centre had to receive special permission from provincial authorities to care for the serpent, as great basin gopher snakes are considered to be a threatened species.

HK students build smallest robot

Hong Kong: A group of four budding engineers at a Hong Kong school broke a Guinness World Record when they constructed the world's smallest humanoid robot.

Aaron Ho Yat Fung, Isaac Zachary To, Justin Wang Tou Duong and Ngo Hei Leung, members of the robotics team at the Diocesan Boys' School, built a robot measuring 5.55 inches tall, .44 inches shorter than the previous record holder, which was made by Zain Ahmad Qureshi in 2022.

Guinness World Records' rules for the smallest humanoid robot category require the automaton to be capable of bipedal movement, as well as be able to articulate its shoulders, elbows, knees and hips.

(Agencies)

Climate change an afterthought in Pakistan poll

AFP
Karachi, Feb. 6

As waves from the Arabian Sea crash into the shores of Pakistan's port city of Karachi, election candidate Ahmad Shabbar tells voters a list of growing but often ignored climate threats.

Pakistan was ravaged by monsoon floods two years ago that left a third of the country submerged, turning climate change into an international rallying cry for the government

But surging inflation and a massive political crackdown on the opposition have pushed the issue down the priority list ahead of polls on Thursday.

"One of the main reasons for me to contest right now is to highlight that climate change is not a priority for these political parties," said scientist and engineer Shabbar, an independent with little chance of being elected.

Despite the climate conversation gaining mainstream traction after the floods -- and billions pledged by donors for the recovery effort -- he says the government is doing little to connect with communities most vulnerable to extreme weather events.

"Before the funds started flowing in, (politicians) weren't really interested in having this conversation," he said.

A small crowd gathered to hear Shabbar explain other environmental issues, such as water scarcity and poor air quality in Karachi, Pakistan's economic capital with a population of more than 20 million.

"Climate change is evident around the world," attendee Amna Jamil, 60, said.

The floods -- which scientists said were linked to climate change -- hit hardest in southern Sindh province, where the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) was running the provincial government.

PPP senator and former climate minister Sherry Rehman insists her party has "put green development and climate resilience at the centre of (its) economic agenda" while others pay "lip service".

They say they have started with the construction of climate-resilient housing in vulnerable areas and would prioritise a developing early-warning infrastructure and a transition to clean energy.

"Pakistan is going through a climate polycrisis, so pretty much everything has to be addressed with speed and action," Rehman told AFP.

Apart from flooding, Pakistan has been scorched by deadly heatwaves, and its smog levels rank among the worst in the world.

Professor Nausheen H. Anwar, who works on urban planning and climate hazards, said "the level of intervention required to make things work at a major scale is not happening".

The impact of climate change has collided with Pakistan's lack of infrastructure and poor governance to produce an ecological catastrophe, she explained.



PHOTO: AFP

Independent candidate Ahmad Shabbar says climate change is not a priority for the main political parties in Pakistan, despite the country facing devastating floods two years ago and now hit by water scarcities.

TODAY IN HISTORY

457 – Leo I becomes the Eastern Roman emperor.
1756 – Guaraní War: The leader of the Guaraní rebels, Sepé Tiaraju, is killed in a skirmish with Spanish and Portuguese troops.
1783 – American Revolutionary War: French and Spanish forces lift the Great Siege of Gibraltar.
1795 – The 11th Amendment to the United States Constitution is ratified.
1812 – The strongest in a series of earthquakes strikes New Madrid, Missouri.
1813 – In the action of 7 February 1813 near the Îles de Los, the frigates Aréthuse and Amelia batter each other, but neither can gain the upper hand.
1819 – Sir Thomas Stamford Raffles leaves Singapore after just taking it over, leaving it in the hands of William Farquhar.
1863 – HMS Orpheus sinks off the coast of Auckland, New Zealand, killing 189.
1900 – Second Boer War: British troops fail in their third attempt to lift the Siege of Ladysmith.

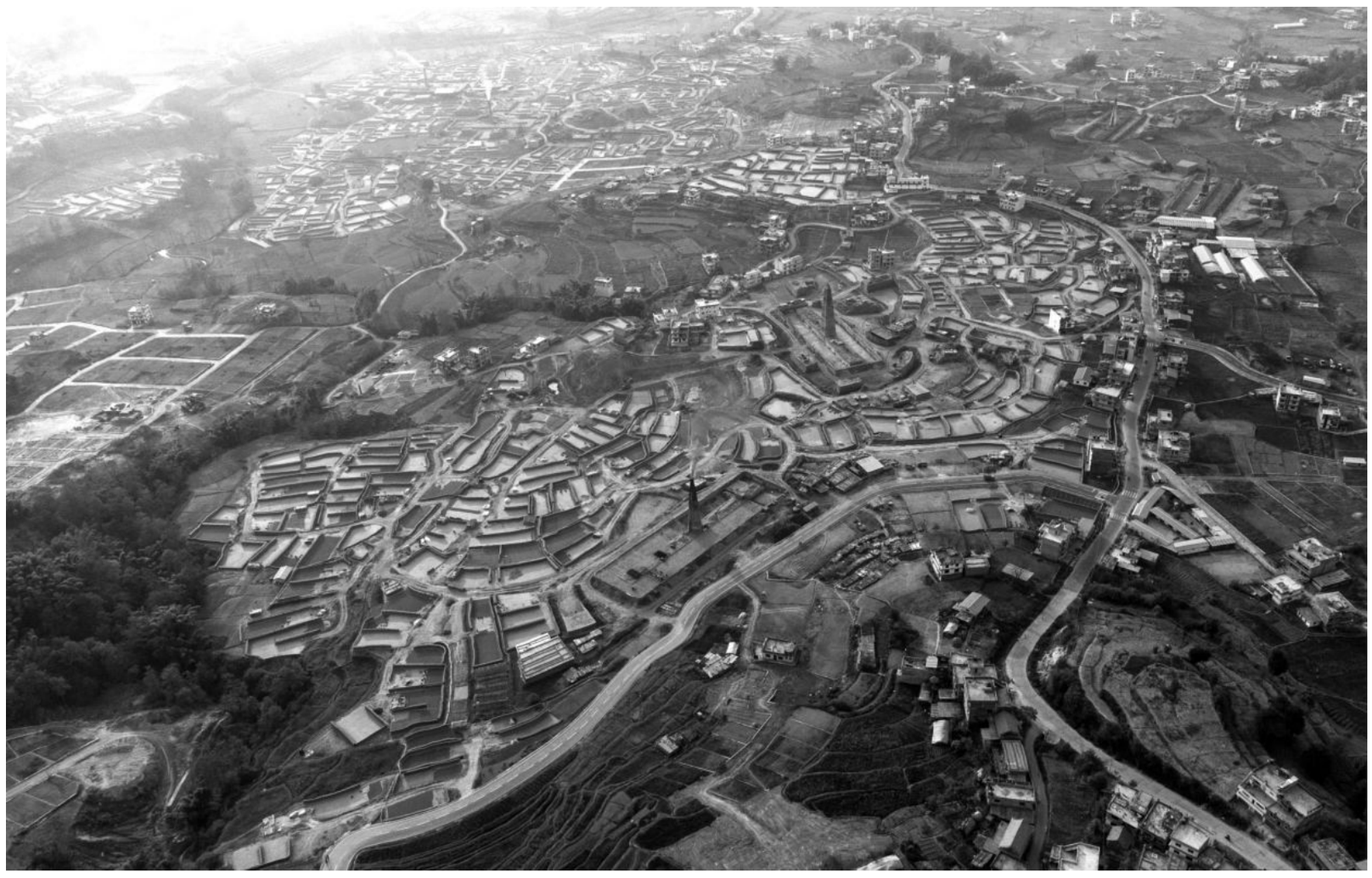


PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

An aerial view of brick kilns in Bhaktapur. Bricks are mostly produced in winter.

Nepal is model for inter-faith harmony: religious leaders

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb 6

Despite the religious diversity, Nepal is a model country for inter-religious harmony, the leaders of different religions stated.

On the occasion of World Interfaith Harmony Week, the religious leaders said this at a programme organised by the National Inter-Religious Network (NIRN)-Nepal in Kathmandu.

Lately, international organisations have also set programmes to praise the role of religious leaders for the end of harmful traditional practices, so the role of religious leaders should be increased, said Jib Prasad Pokharel, Islamic religious leader.

Damodar Gautam, President of the Inter-Religious Council, said that since various elements have started to be active in Nepal to disturb religious harmony, therefore, religious leaders of all religions should unite and move forward.

He further said that a person who commits violence and injustice cannot be a religious leader.

Rati Shrestha, Vice President of NIRN, said that marking the World Interfaith Harmony Week started as per the resolution of the United Nations General Assembly.

Nahida Banu, the manager of NIRN, informed that it was possible to put an end to the evils in the society by organising various programmes through inter-religious activities. Banu informed that they were able to cancel 58 child marriages from 2020 to 2023 in the initiation of religious leaders. Banu also informed that school enrollment also increased in their initiation.

Christian pastor Mahendra Bhattarai said that the media should not promote politics held in the name of religion.

Deepak Acharya, manager of CIN, said that media are playing a role in religious harmony as well as social transformation by spreading the voices of religious leaders to everyone.

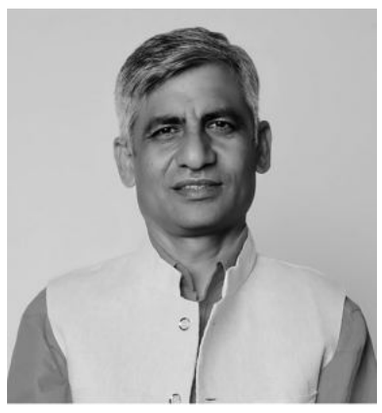
Monk Piyadassi Maharjan, the president of NIRN Nepal, informed that the organisation was working to reduce harmful practices of the society as per the suggestion of stakeholders.

CM Karki stresses dowry-free society

BY JAYA KRISHAN YADAV
Inaruwa, Feb. 6

Kedar Karki, Chief Minister of Koshi Province, has said that building a dowry-free society is the need of the hour.

Speaking at the cultural programme held at the Bhokraha Narsingh Rural Municipality of Sunsari



on Tuesday, Chief Minister Karki said that the social anomalies should be eliminated to ensure good governance and prosperity in the nation.

Remembering the senior congress leader late Khalil Miya, Karki said that Miya had raised the voice for the education of girls.

"Now, the people of Sunsari need to raise their voices against the dowry system to ensure that no woman faces violence in the name of dowry," he added.

In a different context, Chief Minister Karki said that the Koshi Province government was ready to move forward differently and had launched a programme of free treatment for children aged below 10 years.

He said that if necessary, the budget of the temple, masque, and monastery could be curtailed, but the free treatment of children should not be halted on any pretext.

He also urged one and all to educate children and urged the concerned authorities to enhance the quality of education and connect it with income-generation activities. Skilled human resources and sustainable development are the main agenda, he added.

Stating that Muslims have also contributed to the unification of Nepal, he said that it was the responsibility of the government to protect and develop all languages, cultures and ethnicities.

Swine fever outbreak worries Tanahun farmers

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Feb. 6

Farmers in Tanahun district are grappling with concerns following the outbreak of 'African Swine Fever,' resulting in the unexpected death of pigs. The lack of a vaccine has posed challenges in controlling the disease, leading to the demise of livestock for several farmers.

Over the past week, 34 male pigs succumbed to the disease. Seventeen pigs of Balkumari Malla from Kumal village, Myagde Rural Municipality-4 were among the casualties. Malla, an affected farmer, reported a staggering loss exceeding Rs. 110,000 due to the death of his adult livestock.

Expressing worries about repaying farm-related loans, Malla urged the government to extend relief to farmers facing financial setbacks.

He emphasized the necessity for compensation to prevent professionals from abandoning their livelihoods, proposing an arrangement for full damage coverage through insurance assessments.

Dr. Rajesh Kumar Chowdhury, Head of the Veterinary Hospital and Animal Services Expert Centre in Tanahun, disclosed that a total of 34 pigs have succumbed to the disease in Myagde Rural Municipality, Byas Municipality, Bhimad Municipality, and Bhanu Municipality.

To mitigate further losses, he conducted training sessions for prominent pig farmers, advocating the adoption of biological safety measures. Farmers were instructed to refrain from unnecessary visits to other farms, use dedicated clothing and footwear, and practice hand and foot washing after working in the cages.



Furthermore, farmers were advised to implement regular disinfection measures, such as spraying lime, phenol, or disinfectants around the farm cages. The public have been urged to promptly inform the nearest animal service branch, veterinary hospital, or animal service expert centre if any health problems or symptomatic appearances are noticed.

In response to the outbreak, farmers have been directed to dispose of waste responsibly, disinfect farm areas, and keep cages empty. Feeding practices were also emphasised, recommending the boiling of feed items for at least half an hour and avoiding the inclusion of meat-mixed food. Proper waste disposal measures were stressed, discouraging the disposal of dead or cut meat, bones, and other waste in open areas or water sources.

Symptoms of the African Swine Fever include simultaneous illness in multiple pigs, high fever, refusal to eat or drink, weakness, appearance of red or blue spots on the ears and muzzle, and subsequent reddening of the entire body.

Other signs include bleeding from the nose, rapid breathing, vomiting, and a distended abdomen resembling that of pregnant pigs.

Rudra Singh Thakuri, an animal health technician at the centre, confirmed the presence of African Swine Fever through lab tests in Kathmandu after observing fever and distinct spots on the ears, mouth, and throat of the affected pigs.

'Misuse of...

There have been problems because the unions are misused," she said.

On the Bill that was registered at the federal parliament some three years ago to pave the way for establishment of a security printing press, the Minister said, "If the Bill has mentioned anything regarding the employees, we will look at it. Otherwise, I think there is no need to mention anything or consider amendment."

Prior to that, parliamentarian Mahesh Bartaula, on the behalf of those seeking amendment in the Bill, said that the security printing press was a matter of national importance and pride, and thus suggested to use polymers (polymeric materials) to print bank notes.

He viewed that the special attention should be paid towards the aspects of sensitive, credibility and confidentially when it came to security printing press and spoke of the need to recruit permanent, dedicated and committed employees for maintaining that.

According to him, over Rs 12 billion was being sent abroad annually for lack of a security printing press in the country and thus pressed for the need for the parliament to provide legal ground to prevent money from going abroad.

Furthermore, he urged the parliament to put legal provision in place now for the foreigners to avail service from security printing press.

Foreign exchange reserves...

Similarly, balance of payment remained at a surplus of Rs. 273.52 billion in the review period against a surplus of Rs. 92.15 billion in the same period of the previous year.

In US dollar terms, the BOP remained at a surplus of 2.06 billion in the review period against a surplus of 697.4 million in the same period of the previous year.

Inflation drops

Meanwhile, the consumer price inflation has decreased during the first six months of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year. The y-o-y consumer price inflation moderated to 5.26 per cent in mid-January 2024 compared to 7.26 per cent a year ago.

Food and beverage category inflation stood at 5.77 per cent whereas non-food and service category inflation stood at 4.85 per cent in the review period.

Under the food and beverage category, the y-o-y price index of ghee and oil, vegetable and meat and fish sub-category decreased by 13.07 per cent, 1.04 per cent and 0.06 per cent respectively in the review months.

The y-o-y price index of spices sub-category increased by 35.60 per cent, cereal grains and their products by 11.38 per cent, pulses and legumes by 11.14 per cent, milk products and eggs by 10.29 per cent and fruits by 10.15 per cent.

Under the non-food and services category, the y-o-y price index of the transportation sub-category decreased by 1.62 per cent in the review month.

The y-o-y price index of recreation and culture sub-category increased by 12.84 per cent, miscellaneous goods and services by 9.73 per cent, education by 8.92 per cent, furnishing and household equipment by 5.18 per cent and clothes and footwear by 4.96 per cent.

The y-o-y wholesale price inflation stood at 3.36 per cent in mid-January 2024 compared to 9.82 per cent a year ago.

The y-o-y salary and wage rate index increased by 5.56 per cent in mid-January 2024 compared to 10.27 per cent a year ago.

Nepal, Italy agree to revitalise...

Prof. Maurizio Gallo highlighted the history, collaborative projects in past, new collaboration, and opportunities for the future in the Pyramid Laboratory. Dr. Rabindra Prasad Dhakal, Secretary of NAST, spoke about the history and the new collaboration opportunities for the Pyramid Laboratory.

Likewise, Dr. Franco Salerno shared the main scientific results, which was recently published in nature and other esteemed journals along with other publications and other achievements.

The BTC meeting discussed further about the activities of the scientific projects presented by both parties for execution in the next three years, in order to approve the research proposals and other activities. Regarding the activities to be executed, the BTC members reviewed 14 projects on the Nepali side and 19 projects on the Italian side.

The BTC meeting recommended that every project approved by the BTC can be implemented in Nepal and at the Pyramid Observatory Laboratory, provided it has the necessary financial coverage.

Similarly, it is recommended that the Italian projects will support the Nepali researchers for their living operational costs and potentially activating Ph.D. and masters level scholarships as far as possible.

The meeting also suggested that the NAST should be informed of the implementation of any individual project at least 4 months earlier in order to facilitate its execution by providing necessary support for the release of authorizations, permits, licenses as required by Nepali law.

Pandey named general secretary of...

However, initially, President Paudel did not act on these recommendations, citing various reasons such as the non-acceptance of the resignation of the then General Secretary Bharat Raj Gautam and Pandey's continued service as the Secretary of the House of Representatives.

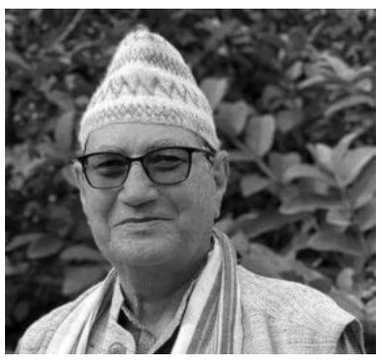
Amidst these considerations, President Paudel eventually acted on the recommendations and appointed Pandey as the General Secretary . This move aligns with Pandey's recent resignation from the Secretary of the House of Representatives.

The appointment marks a crucial development in the administrative structure of the Federal Parliament, following a period of deliberation and reminders from Speaker Ghimire and National Assembly Speaker Timilsina to implement the earlier recommendation.

The President's office confirmed that the decision was in line with the memorandum recommendation and Pandey's resignation from his previous position.

NC leader Budhathoki passes away at 80

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Birtamod, Feb. 6



Nepali Congress leader and former minister Keshav Kumar Budhathoki died at the Biratnagar-based Birat Medical College on Monday at around 11:30 pm. He was 80.

Budhathoki, who is an NC central committee member, was undergoing treatment for kidney-related illness. He was also suffering from prostate cancer for a long time. An outspoken and bold person, Budhathoki was popular among people as Kumar Budhathoki in Jhapa.

Born in Singfring, Ilam, in October 1944, Budhathoki had been living in Arjundhara Municipality, Jhapa, after his family migrated from Ilam when he was a student.

As he was popular among the people, he was elected Pradhan Pancha, District Panchayat president and member of Rastriya Panchayat and served as assistant minister during the Panchayat period. He revolted against the Panchayat during the 1990 movement, supporting the Nepali Congress-led political movement by resigning from the post of assistant minister. But later, he joined the Rastriya Prajatantra Party.

However, he returned to the Nepali Congress and was elected to the Constituent Assembly in 2008 and 2013 and served as General Administrative Minister. He was elected as the party's central committee member in the 14th general convention of the NC held in 2021.

Meanwhile, an emergency meeting of the Nepali Congress held on Tuesday expressed deep sorrow over the demise of Budhathoki and passed a condolence proposal.

According to a statement issued by chief secretary of the Nepali Congress Central Office Krishna Prasad Paudel, in the condolence message, the NC expressed deep sorrow over the demise of leader Budhathoki, wished eternal peace to the departed soul and condoled the bereaved family.

The party also decided to lower the party flag at half-mast in party offices of all levels for three days beginning from Tuesday and put off all programmes scheduled for these days. The party also decided to close all party offices across the country on Wednesday and hold condolence meetings on the 13th day of his demise in his home district Jhapa.

Likewise, the party has put off the remaining programmes of the ongoing 'NC in Community Campaign' until further notice citing the untimely demise of Budhathoki. Budhathoki is survived by his wife, two sons and a daughter.

Awarding Sati Devi as best film, Sauraha SA Film Festival concludes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6



'Sati Devi' directed by Laxman Subedi won the Best Film Award in the five-day Sauraha South Asian Film Festival.

The festival, organised by Caravan Nepal from February 1 to 5 in Sauraha, Chitwan, concluded on Monday by presenting the prestigious title and a cash prize of Rs. 50,000 to Sati Devi.

Director Subedi received the award from Gyanu Regmi, the wife of the late director Shiva Regmi and their son Dr. Abhishek Regmi.

Likewise, Dr. Sachin Ghimire and Gaurav KC received the best documentary award for their work 'Ma Alap Huna Chahanchhu' along with a cash prize of Rs. 25,000.

Pradip Pokharel's 'Snow Leopard' bagged the award of Rs. 25,000 for Best Short Film.

Banisha Shah was recognised as the Best Editor for 'Nango Gaun.'

Sankalp Bhujel received the Best Cinematographer award for 'Bichchhed,' while Satyaraj Chaulagain and Mukun Bhusal were honoured with the Best Screenwriting Award for the same film.

Likewise, the 'Jury Encouragement Award' was presented to Roshan Kumar Shrestha's musical film 'Bhagya.'

Over 40 films from South Asian countries participated in the festival and 20 of them were screened.

Awards and accolades were presented by Geeta Gurung, a member of the Bagmati Provincial Assembly to outstanding filmmakers and films.

Love Pyakurel, a senior documentary director, was the jury coordinator.

Bimal Poudel, President of Caravan Nepal, expressed the commitment to hosting the festival annually in Sauraha.

He announced that if the government provided two bighas of land, he would build a movie museum, an ashram for elderly filmmakers, and a state-of-the-art studio for indoor shooting. Speaking on the occasion, Provincial Assembly member Gurung pledged to raise her voice in the Assembly and coordinate with the local government for the support.

Mongolian Heart performing in South Korea



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Mongolian Heart, established as a group singing ensemble, is set to perform in South Korea after a five-year hiatus. The band had previously performed in Australia in April last year and is currently gearing up for musical performances in South Korea.

Boby Lama, the band's manager and guitarist, announced that their performances in Korea would begin on coming Friday.

The band's lead singer, Raju Lama, will be showcasing their popular songs in the musical programme organised by the Nepal Korea Cultural Exchange Association.

"We are thrilled to be performing in Korea after five years, and we are determined to astonish the audience," stated Boby Lama. Raju Lama, the band's lead singer, rose to fame after the band was established in 1992.

Known for their folk, slow rock, and pop melody music, the band comprises guitarist Boby Lama, Santosh Thapa Magar on drums, Bhupendra Bajracharya on lead guitar, Pawan Kapali on bass, Binaya Maharjan on flute and Baburaja Maharjan on Madal.

Songs like 'Badal Pariko Deshbaat,' 'Ma Maya Laaudina,' 'Halla Chalechha,' 'Timilai Dekhera,' 'Prakhaima,' and 'Sayad Timro Baama' are among the band's hit numbers.

Shooting of Khusma begins in Manang



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Manang, Feb. 6

Shooting of 'Khusma,' starring Dhiraj Magar and Upasana Singh Thakuri began in Manang on January 24.

Magar and Thakuri are sharing the screen for the first time.

This location was chosen by the production team primarily for its scenic snow-covered landscapes, which are integral to the film's storyline.

Directed by newcomer Ashok Thapa Magar, 'Khusma' boasts a production team including Betane Magar, Chandra Bhattachan, Mohan Rai and Sushmita Budhathoki.

SD Yogi is handling the music composition while Deepak Bajracharya is in charge of cinematography.

Apart from the lead pair, the film features Astitwa Bhattachan, Khadk Bahadur Pun and Arun Magar.

As part of the production schedule, there's a plan to venture to Rukum for 10 days to capture additional scenic shots for the film.

Miss Japan gives up her title after an article about her affair with a married man

AP
Tokyo, Feb. 6

The Ukrainian-born winner of this year's Miss Japan beauty pageant and the contest's organizers say she has renounced her title after a magazine published an article about her affair with a married man.

Carolina Shiino was crowned Miss Japan on Jan. 22, setting off public discussion on an old question about what it means to be Japanese in a country where homogeneity and conformity are still valued.

In a message posted on her Instagram site on Monday, Shiino said that after the article came out, she offered to renounce her crown and resign from her modeling agency over it. She says her offer was accepted.

The Associated Press could not immediately reach Shiino for comment.

The Weekly Bunshun magazine reported last week that Shiino had been in a relationship with a doctor who is married. Initially, she appeared to confirm the relationship but said she did not know he was married.

Later, she said her earlier explanation "was not true" and that she was aware of his marriage status and that he had a family. She was in a state of shock and fear over the report, and panicked, which is why she was not able to tell the truth, Shiino said, and apologised.

"I'm very sorry for causing the tremendous trouble and for acting as if betraying everyone who has supported me," she said on Instagram. Shiino also apologised to the man's partner and his family, as well as other parties involved.

The office of Miss Japan organisers on Tuesday said that Shiino's renunciation of the title was accepted and added that the slot for the 2024 winner would remain empty.

The organization also said it "takes responsibility" for the ruckus and apologized to sponsors, judges and others involved for "the trouble." It said it initially defended Shiino, based on her initial explanation that the man she was involved with had told her he was divorced and that she broke up with him when she learned otherwise.



> The office of Miss Japan organisers on Tuesday said that Shiino's renunciation of the title was accepted and added that the slot for the 2024 winner would remain empty.

The scandal reignited a wave of criticism of Shiino on social media but also raised some questions about why she was the only one blamed for the affair while the man who was involved with her has not made a single public comment.

In Japan's male-dominated culture, women are still expected to be good mothers and wives, and are publicly chastised more than the men in case of extra-marital affairs.

Last year, famous Japanese actress Ryoko Hirosue's acting agency suspended her indefinitely from her work contracts over her alleged affair with a married celebrity chef.

Shiino has lived in Japan since moving to the country at the age of 5. Fluent in Japanese, she became a naturalized citizen in 2022. She had worked as a model and said she has as strong a sense of Japanese identity as anyone else, despite her Caucasian look.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Making progress toward your goals is possible now. While the eye-catching Moon in your public 10th house aligns with abundant Jupiter in your money zone, the people around you may be surprised to see some of the bold financial .

Taurus: You may currently appreciate the stability of a friend group or community that has been part of your life for a long time. That said, you're probably not the same person you were when you first got involved.

Gemini: Receiving help to reach your goals is presently possible. Due to the perceptive Moon in your sharing sector noticing focused Saturn in your ambitious 10th house, the effort you put in is likely obvious to potential collaborators.

Cancer: A friend may currently guide you toward some needed perspective on your political or spiritual beliefs. You don't necessarily have to abandon the main tenets that provide structure to your life, but there could be a less restrictive way of viewing.

Leo: You're equipped to deliver focused effort with careful attention to detail today. As the anxious Moon in your responsible 6th house looks to inhibited Saturn in your sharing sector, you could be hoping to impress a collaborator who seems stern and hard to please.

Virgo: Bringing a close relationship out of a rut may be necessary at any moment. You possibly appreciate being able to rely on this person's stability, but sometimes you need more than that.

Libra: You're likely looking for security at this time, and your willingness to work hard could help you achieve it. That said, you shouldn't have to rely exclusively on your own effort.

Scorpio: Feeling like you're not having enough fun could weigh on you at the moment. While the connection-seeking Moon in your communication zone aligns with repressive Saturn in your 5th House of Entertainment, you might.

Sagittarius: Reining in your money worries is presently possible. While the nervous Moon in your finance zone reaches out to stable Saturn in your security sector, you could notice that you're already doing better than you thought you were.

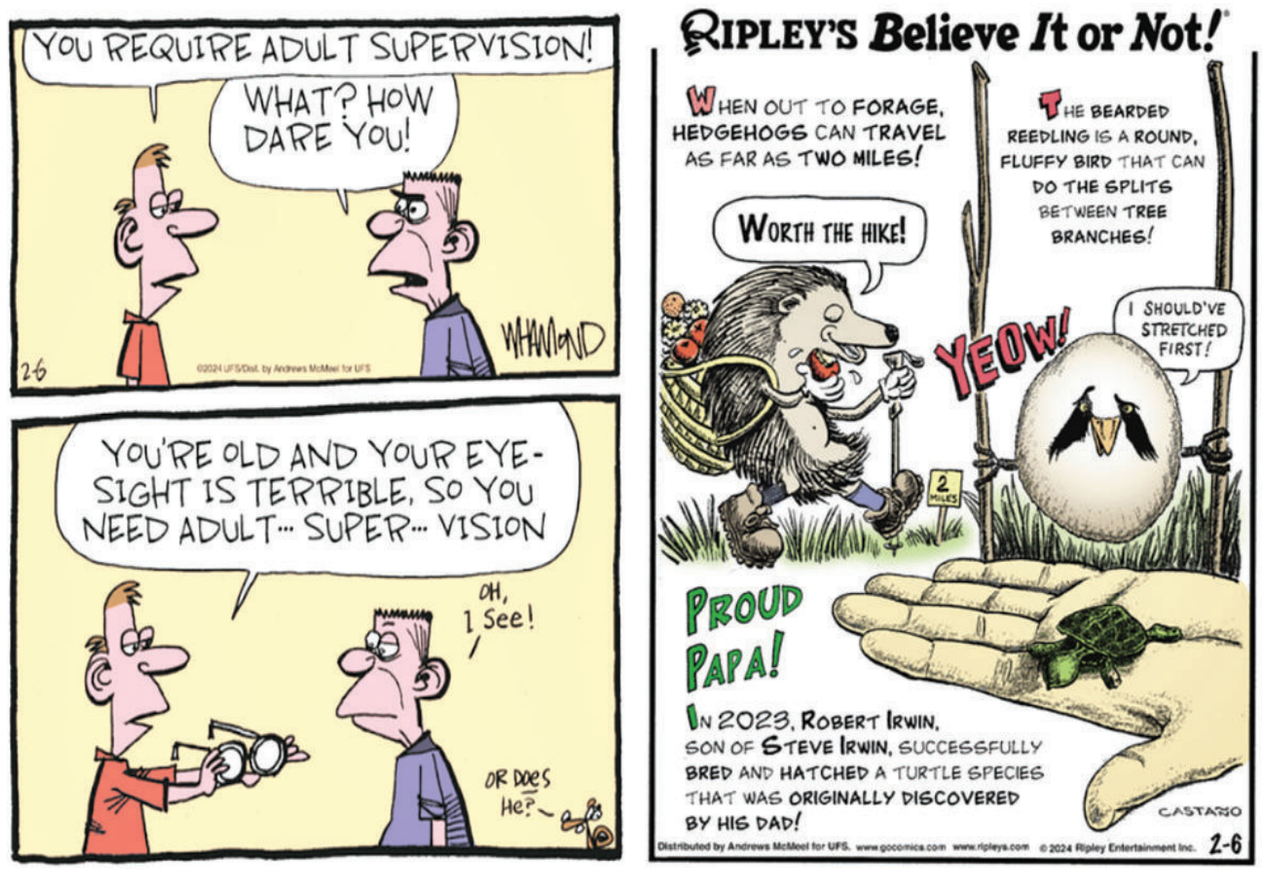
Capricorn: Your emotions are potentially close to the surface right now. While the sensitive Moon in your sign leans on solid Saturn in your communication zone, you're equipped to express your feelings in a way that you have control over.

Aquarius: Digging deeper into your roots could presently be rewarding for you. As the inquisitive Moon in your 12th House of Secrets nudges stuck Saturn in your finance sector, learning about your background.

Pisces: The chatter could currently be wild in a friend group or organization you belong to. As the impulsive Moon in your social sector connects to restrained Saturn in your sign, you might feel the need to tell others that they're being unrealistic..

CARTOON

gocomics.com



NEPAL DRAWN WITH SYRIA, IRAQ, PALESTINE IN WAFF 2024

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6

Nepal's football team is facing Syria, Iraq and Palestine in the group-stage of the West Asian Football Federation (WAFF) Women's Championship 2024 kicking off in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, on February 19.

The championship is being participated by eight teams divided into two groups. While Nepal is in Group B, Saudi Arabia, Guam, Lebanon and Jordan are in Group A.

The top two teams from the groups will play in the semi-finals, the organisers informed. All the group matches are being played at Hall Stadium, King Abdullah Sports City.

Nepal will play its first group match against Syria on February 20. The women's team will be facing Iraq and Palestine on February 22 and 24 respectively.

It is the eighth edition of WAFF Women's Championship and Nepal is participating in the tournament for the first time. Despite being a South Asian country, Nepal is an invited team in the tournament of West Asian countries.

With the first edition of the championship hosted by Jordan in 2005, Jordan has lifted the trophy five times (2005, 2007, 2014, 2019 and 2022). The UAE has won the championship twice in 2010 and 2011.

NSJF Pulsar Sports Award

Nominees for best young player, coach named

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 6



The Nepal Sports Journalist Forum (NSJF) on Tuesday made public the nominees under the best young player and best coach categories for the NSJF Pulsar Sports Award 2079. The award ceremony is being held on February 11.

According to the NSJF, while five individuals were nominated in each category until the last edition of the award, as many deserving individuals as possible have been nominated from this year.

"Eight individuals each have been nominated in the first phase for the best young player and best coach. Three of the best among the eight individuals from both categories will be selected and made public within some days," read a statement signed by NSJF's general secretary Prajwal Oli.

NSJF had already unveiled the nominees for the Best Male and Female players. Deepak Adhikari (Athletics), Aasif Sheikh (Cricket), Mukesh Pal (Athletics), Rohit Paudel (Cricket), Nasir Yahya Hussain (Swimming), Man Bahadur Shrestha (Volleyball), Subash Tamang (Golf), Rupesh Jaiswal (Chess) were the nominees named for Best Male player award.

In the same manner, Rajpura Pachhai (Athletics), Pushpa Bhandari (Athletics), Punam Shrestha (Judo), Jayarani Tharu (Athletics), Shrebee Maharjan (Triathlon), Duwana Lama (Swimming), Anusha Malla (Basketball) and Amisha Karki (Basketball) are the players nominated in the Best Female player of the year category.

Best young players

The eight youths nominated for 'best young player' are Rammaya Budha (athletics), Sushma Tamang (boxing), Sujata Tamang (football), Unesh Budhathoki (football), Bijay Bata (boxing), Dev Khanal (cricket), Dipesh Kandel (cricket) and Sadbhav Acharya (golf).

Rammaya Budha won a silver each in the individual and team event at the 16th Asian Cross Country Championship, a gold and a silver at Golden Athletics Meet and a gold in Devdaha Half Marathon among others.

Sushma Tamang won a silver in the ASBC Asian U22 Boxing Championships and got qualified for the IBA Women's World Boxing Championships. She also won a gold for Bagmati Province at the 9th National Games.

Bijay Bata won a bronze in the ASBC Asian U22 Boxing Championships and a silver at the 9th National Games. Dev Khanal and Dipesh Kandel have been nominated for their performances in the qualifiers to help the team book its berth at the ICC U19 World Cup 2024.

Sujata Tamang was the best goalkeeper at SAFF U15 Championship and SAFF U17 Championship held in Bangladesh in the same year. Nepal won the U15 championship.

Unesh Budhathoki was in the Nepal U17 squad which was the runner-up in SAFF U17 Championship. He was the joint highest scorer in the tournament (4 goals).

Sadbhav Acharya won a gold alongside Subash Tamang at Nepal Tourism Cup and Bangladesh Amateur Golf Championship. Acharya also won a gold for Bagmati Province and an individual silver at the 9th National Games.

Best coaches

Eight coaches nominated for the 'best coach award' are Chandra Gurung (athletics), Dipak Maharjan (boxing), Bhagwati Rana Magar (football), Ananta Raj Thapa (football), Bharat Shah (volleyball), Ongden Lama (swimming), Jagat Tamata (cricket) and Monty Desai (cricket).

Ananta Raj Thapa coached Nepali women's team to become the runners-up at SAFF Women's Championship.

He was the first coach to lead the women's team to a win against India for the first time and to draw two more friendly matches against India. Bhagwati Rana Magar coached the women's team who won the SAFF U15 Championship in Bangladesh.

Bharat Shah was the coach when the men's and women's national team won a silver each at the CAVA Central Zone Beach Volleyball.

Chandra Gurung's coaching led Nepali athletes to win two gold and a bronze in senior category and two silvers and a bronze in junior category at 16th Asian Cross Country Championship.

Dipak Maharjan coached the players in the men's and women's categories to win a silver and three bronze medals at ASBC Asian U22 Boxing Championships.

Ongden Lama helped Tribhuwan Army Club win 20 gold, nine silver and seven bronze medals at 9th National Games.

SNIPPETS

India knocks Nepal out

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepal's U19 women's football team was knocked out of the SAFF U19 Championship after losing to India 4-0 in Dhaka, Bangladesh, on Tuesday. Losing to Bangladesh and winning against Bhutan, Nepal had to defeat India to progress further. However, Nepali young girls could not register a win. While the first half ended goalless, India scored four goals in the second half. Neha netted the first in the 54th minute.

Three other goals came in the final 10 minutes. Neha extended the lead to two goals in the 80th minute after scoring her second from outside the 18-yard box. Sulanjana Raul trebled the lead in the 85th minute. With three minutes of injury time added in the end, substitute Cindy Remruatpuii Colney killed the match with the fourth goal in 90+2 minutes.

TU dominates University Sports

Kathmandu (TRN): Tribhuvan University (TU) emerged victorious in the 1st University Sports competition on Tuesday, having won a total of 19 gold medals, eight silver medals, and three bronze medals. Sudurpaschim University came in second place with three gold, four silver, and nine bronze medals, while Lumbini University secured the third position with one gold, two silver, and two bronze medals.

Nepal Sanskrit University also participated and won one silver and one bronze medal. The competition involved players from 10 universities in Nepal, who competed in Table Tennis, Athletics, Badminton, and Volleyball, vying for a total of 23 gold medals.

Japan provides 240 Judo Uniforms

Kathmandu (TRN): Kikuta Yutaka, Ambassador of Japan to Nepal, handed over 240 Judo uniforms to the Nepal Judo Association at the Embassy of Japan in Kathmandu on Tuesday. The uniforms were received by Deepak Harsha Bajracharya, president of the association. Bajracharya was accompanied by Debu Thapa, who competed in the Beijing 2008 Olympics. The Judo uniforms were provided by the All Japan Judo Federation (AJJF) and the non-profit organization JUDOs, under the Project for Sports Diplomacy Enhancement by the Government of Japan.

"The Embassy of Japan hopes that the judo uniforms handed over today will encourage the enthusiasm of Nepali judo lovers, thus will play a positive role in the healthy growth of the Nepali youth, who are the future of Nepal," read a statement by the embassy.

Squad named for ACC Premier Cup

Kathmandu (TRN): The Cricket Association of Nepal has unveiled the women's national squad for the upcoming ACC Women's Premier Cup on Tuesday. The tournament is scheduled to take place in Malaysia from February 10th to 18th. Led by Indu Barma, the team consists of Bindu Rawal, Rubina Chhetry, Sita Rana Magar, Kajol Shrestha, Puja Mahato, Sangita Rai, Apsari Begam, Kabita Joshi, Kabita Kunwar, Samjhana Khadka, Roma Thapa, Dolly Bhatta, and Ashmina Karmacharya. The team is being coached by Manoj Katwal.

NZ takes big lead over SAfrica

AP
Mount Maunganui, Feb. 6



Kane Williamson followed his century in the first innings with another as New Zealand led South Africa by 528 runs with six second-innings wickets in hand at stumps Tuesday on the third day of the first test.

Williamson became only the fifth New Zealander after Glenn Turner, Geoff Howarth, Andrew Jones and Peter Fulton to score centuries in each innings of a test. He scored 118 in New Zealand's first innings of 511 — his 30th test century — and added his 31st Tuesday before being dismissed for 109 close to stumps.

Williamson took 241 balls to reach a century on the first day but only 125 balls to repeat the feat as New Zealand piled on runs after choosing not to enforce the follow-on.

He finally was out stumped by Clyde Fortuin from the bowling of Neil Brand chasing runs, only the third time Williamson has been dismissed in that manner in 97 tests. At stumps, New Zealand was 179-4 with Daryl Mitchell on 11 and Tom Blundell 5.

Rachin Ravindra couldn't follow his maiden double century in the first innings with another but he added his first two wickets in tests as New Zealand bowled out South Africa for 162 in reply to its first innings of 511, a first-innings lead of 349.

With its seam bowlers fully rested after sharing 42 overs in the South Africa innings, New Zealand should be in a position to declare on the fourth day with time available to bowl out South Africa for a second time.

The pitch at Bay Oval has flattened out but could be difficult in the fourth innings if it cracks after four days under a hot sun. Ravindra (2-16) and left-arm spinner Mitchell Santner (3-34) shared five wickets Tuesday as the pitch showed signs of turn.

South Africa resumed Tuesday at 80-4 and was in deeper trouble when it lost three wickets before lunch, including two in one over bowled by seamer Matt Henry.

David Bedingham was 29 not out overnight and fell to Henry on 32 while Ruan de Swardt fell lbw for a duck two balls later. The New Zealand seamers bowled wicket to wicket, keeping the lbw in play on a relatively unresponsive pitch.

Santner and Ravindra then wrapped up the South Africa innings. Fortuin fell to Santner before lunch at which South Africa was 129-7. Ravindra dismissed Keegan Petersen (45) for his first wicket in tests.

Petersen was the best of the South Africa batters, staying at the crease almost three hours and facing 132 balls. Santner dismissed Tshepo Moreki and Ravindra bowled Dane Paterson to end the innings.

BAGMATI ENSURES 70% FUNDING FOR GAUTAM BUDDHA INT'L CRICKET STADIUM

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Makwanpur, Feb. 6

The Bagmati Province government has assured to provide 70 per cent of the budget required to make Gautam Buddha International Cricket Stadium in Chitwan playable.

The Cabinet meeting of the Bagmati Province held Tuesday morning decided to cover 70 per cent of the proposed budget for the stadium's construction. Bharatpur Metropolitan City speculates the need for Rs. 750 million to make the ground playable and construct a parapet for 10,000 viewers in the first stage.

"As per an agreement between the provincial government and Bharatpur metropolis, the provincial government has ensured the source for a budget of Rs. 525 million for the stadium," said Shalikram Jamkattel, Chief Minister of Bagmati while making the cabinet decision public.

The provincial government and the metropolis, on November 7, 2023, inked an agreement to cover 70 per cent and 30 per cent of the required investment for the stadium with a preliminary capacity of 10,000.

After the budget assurance, Bagmati Province has requested Bharatpur Metropolis to initiate the tender process.

Meanwhile, the provincial Cabinet also decided to recommend 10/10 projects as asked by the National Planning Commission under matching and special grants. The meeting also decided to reimburse the budget for the projects completed in the last fiscal year.

WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:48 am, Sunset at 5:48 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	23.2	8.4	0.1
Dadeldhura	16.2	3.5	0.2
Dhangadi	22.8	10.2	0.3
Birendranagar	21.4	7.7	0.0
Nepalgunj	22.4	11.0	0.2
Jumla	14.5	-3.5	0.0
Ghorahi	19.1	8.5	0.0
Pokhara	21.4	11.4	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.2	9.5	0.0
Simara	22.7	12.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.8	6.7	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.2	6.0	0.0
Taplejung	13.8	6.4	0.0
Dhankuta	18.2	9.8	0.0
Biratnagar	23.7	13.0	0.0
Jomsom	10.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	23.5	14.5	Traces*
Lumle	14.5	6.1	0.0*
Janakpur	26.0	13.5	0.0*
Jiri	16.7	0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 7, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.60	Rs. 133.20
Euro	1	Rs. 142.33	Rs. 142.98
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.39	Rs. 167.14
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.06	Rs. 152.75
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.10	Rs. 86.49
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 97.99	Rs. 98.43
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.52	Rs.98.96
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.92	Rs. 8.96
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.53
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.36	Rs. 35.52
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.37	Rs. 36.54
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.72	Rs. 3.73
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.10	Rs. 36.27
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.82	Rs. 27.95
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.97	Rs. 10.02
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.49	Rs. 12.55
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.08	Rs. 19.16
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.51	Rs. 432.45
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.72	Rs. 353.32

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Australia take just 6.5 overs to thrash woeful WIndies

AFP
Canberra, Feb. 6

Australia needed just 6.5 overs to thrash a woeful West Indies by eight wickets in an embarrassing end to their one-day international series in Canberra on Tuesday, with Jake Fraser-McGurk slamming 41 off 18 balls.

The hosts won the first game in Melbourne by eight wickets and the second in Sydney by 83 runs to clinch the series, with the West Indies playing for pride.

But after Australia skipper Steve Smith won the toss and sent them in on a humid day, they crumbled to 86 all out in the 25th over against an attack missing Josh Hazlewood, Pat Cummins and Mitchell Starc.

In reply, Australia plundered the runs needed with 259 balls remaining to cap a stunning capitulation by the Caribbean side.

Explosive 21-year-old opener Fraser-McGurk showed his immense talent in only his second match with five fours and three sixes in a quickfire 41 before he was caught going for another big hit off Alzarri Joseph.

Aaron Hardie was the only other wicket to fall, caught behind for two off Oshane Thomas.

Josh Inglis blasted an unbeaten 35 while Smith was not out six.

Earlier, paceman Xavier Bartlett took 4-21 to go with the 4-17 he bagged on his debut in Melbourne. Fellow fast bowler Lance Morris grabbed 2-13 before leaving the field with a side strain.

Bartlett struck early with Kjorn Ottley trapped lbw for eight and, while Athanaze and Keacy Carty steadied the ship, they were in survival mode, with just 36 runs coming from the opening 10 overs.

Their partnership ended when Morris was introduced and grabbed his first international wicket, courtesy of Marnus Labuschagne holding a spectacular diving catch at point to remove Carty for 10.

Skipper Shai Hope needed a big score and drove Morris to the ropes, but he lasted just five balls before falling lbw to Shaun Abbott, leaving the visitors in trouble on 43-3.

Debutant Teddy Bishop soon followed for a duck, undone by the sheer pace of Morris whose fullish ball clattered the middle stump before he left the field midway through his fifth over.

Athanaze was the one shining



light, making a battling 32 off 60 balls before mis-hitting a sweep off spinner Adam Zampa with Abbott collecting a simple catch.

Two more wickets in three balls left the West Indies reeling, with Romario Shepherd out for a golden duck to Bartlett and Matthew Forde run out after a comical mix-up with Roston Chase.

Bartlett then cleaned up the tail with two more wickets.

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